

Fate's Edge

Complete Worldbook

A Gazetteer of the Known Realms

AS TOLD BY THOSE WHO LIVE THERE, BLEED THERE, AND OWE THERE

Contents

Preface: The Ledger Bleeds	5
I The Amaranthine Sea & Northern Shores	17
1 Kahfagia	21
II The Eastern Dolmis & The Valewood	23
2 Theona	27
III The Southern Realms (Akilan)	29
3 Oshiira	33
IV The Way of Silk	35
4 Fhara	39
V Dhahara — The Kingdom of Brass	41
5 The Brass Coast	45
VI The Eastern Realms	49
6 Sihai	53
6.1 Sihai — “The Central Kingdom”	55
7 Nihori	69
VII The Spaces Between	77
8 Ubral	81
Appendix: The Ninth and the Hollow	83

VIII	World Travel & Gateways	87
A	Global Travel Procedures	91
A.1	Core Travel Procedure	91
A.2	Mode Rules	91
A.2.1	Sea Legs	91
A.2.2	Mountain Passes & Underways	91
A.2.3	Desert Legs	91
A.2.4	River Legs	92
A.2.5	Steppe Legs	92
A.2.6	Shadow Corridors	92
A.2.7	Universal Travel Hazards (d18)	93
A.3	Gateways & Control Points	94
A.4	Edgewalker's Notes on Leverage	95
B	Story Beat (SB) Menus	97
B.0.1	Universal SB Spend Menu	97
B.0.2	Regional SB Options (Expanded)	97
B.0.3	Caravan Intent Dial	99
	Regional Currencies Cheat Sheet	99
C	The Ninth Words of the Black Ledger of Khasurah	101
	Colophon	103

Preface: The Ledger Bleeds

I am an Aeler Edgewalker. You call us mountain-dwellers who measure breath in silver bells and seal contracts in stone. How adorably naïve.

We don't just measure breath—we own the lungs that draw it. When a Tulkani chieftain swears an oath on his firstborn's life? That's not honor—it's collateral I've already hypothecated three times over. When a Veiled Sister binds a demon to a corpse to prop up her corpse-throne? That's not terror—it's a futures contract on soul-debt, and I'm the broker who sold the short position before the ritual even began.

You see the surface as “full of problems.” How quaint. Problems aren't obstacles—they're inventory.

This book isn't a tourist's guide. It's a hit list with footnotes. I've marked the places where a well-placed bell doesn't just open a pass—it starts a war I've already shorted the bond market on. Where a forged seal doesn't just move a mountain—it triggers a landslide I've bought mineral rights to before the first crack appeared. Where a single true story doesn't just buy a ship's loyalty—it buys the captain's silence while I sell his manifest to pirates.

You want to build journeys? Draw your cards. Set your timers. Spend your Story Beats like they mean something. But remember: every Diamond you earn is a tooth knocked out of someone else's jaw. Every Debt you incur? I already bought it from your victim for half what you'll pay—and I'm collecting interest in your marrow before you finish reading this sentence.

The road isn't just a ledger. It's a butcher's block. Every gate isn't a clause—it's a throat waiting for the knife.

— *The Edgewalker*

The Cartomancer's Compass

“The world does not speak in words. It speaks in suits, ranks, and the spaces between. Every bridge, every bribe, every broken oath can be laid out on a table of felt and dealt from a worn deck. This is not superstition. It is method.”

— Mira of the Wandering Circle, Tulkani cartomancer

A Tulkani Perspective on the Art

I was seven when my grandmother first placed a deck in my hands. Not a new deck—a worn one, its edges soft as silk, its faces faded by a hundred thousand shuffles. “This is your first threshold,” she said. “Learn to read it, and you will never be lost.”

The Tulkani do not build temples. We build fires. We do not carve scriptures into stone; we let the cards tell us what the road has seen. Cartomancy is our witch-work, our way of reading the Echo (what has been), steadying the Veil (what is), and leaning into Flow (what wishes to be). It is not fortune-telling. It is witnessing—a conversation with the world’s memory, conducted through the language of suits and ranks.

The other peoples of Fate’s Edge have their own names for what we do. The Aeler call us “thread-readers” and hire us to audit their ledgers. The Ykrul call us “bone-speakers” and consult us before every migration. The Ecktorian Inquisition calls us heretics and burns our decks when they find them. We keep shuffling.

This chapter is my gift to the road. It explains how to read the cards as we do—not as a tool for controlling fate, but as a way of listening to what the world has already decided to tell you.

The Four Suits: A Universal Grammar

Every card in every generator carries the same four suit-meanings. They are the alphabet of the world’s witness. In the Tulkani tradition, we say the suits are the four breaths of the world:

♠ Spades: Place — The Stage

Where does the scene happen? ♠ is the threshold, the landmark, the ground beneath the action. It answers: *Where are we?*

- **High rank (10–A):** A major landmark—a fortress, a capital, a haunted ruin. The place has a name that echoes in local songs.
- **Mid rank (6–9):** A functional location—a ford, a market, a shrine. The place has a purpose and a keeper.
- **Low rank (2–5):** A liminal or neglected place—a crossroads, a collapsed bridge, a smuggler’s cove. The place is defined by what it lacks.

In the regional chapters, ♠ entries are always places. See, for example, the bridges and canals of Silkstrand or the cairns and passes of Ubral.

♥ Hearts: Actor — The Face

Who drives the scene? ♥ is the person, the faction, the voice that speaks. It answers: *Who is here?*

- **High rank (J–A):** An elite, a ruler, a power-broker. The actor has authority and reach beyond the immediate scene.
- **Mid rank (6–10):** A professional, a functionary, a skilled operator. The actor has a trade and a price.
- **Low rank (2–5):** A commoner, an outcast, a victim. The actor needs something or has been failed by someone.

In the regional chapters, ♥ entries are always people or factions. See the merchants and spies of the Brass Coast or the spirit-wardens of the Mistlands.

♣ Clubs: Pressure — The Complication

What pushes back? ♣ is the storm, the burden, the knife in the dark. It answers: *What goes wrong?*

- **High rank (10–A):** A catastrophe, a betrayal, an invasion. The complication changes the shape of the journey.
- **Mid rank (6–9):** A serious obstacle—a feud, a quarantine, a broken bridge. The complication costs time, resources, or reputation.
- **Low rank (2–5):** A minor hazard—a sudden squall, a lost token, a raised toll. The complication is a nuisance, not a disaster.

In the regional chapters, ♣ entries are always complications or threats. See the river floods and witness-cord cuts of Ayokha or the market riots of Silkstrand.

♦ Diamonds: Leverage — The Reward

What opens the door? ♦ is the token, the writ, the secret that changes Position. It answers: *What do you gain?*

- **High rank (J–A):** A major asset—a noble title, a keystone charter, a general pardon. The reward reshapes the party's standing.
- **Mid rank (6–10):** A significant tool—a pass-stone, a witness cord, a lighthouse charter. The reward solves a specific class of problem.
- **Low rank (2–5):** A minor advantage—a bridge token, a guest-cup, a rumor. The reward grants a single use of improved Position.

In the regional chapters, ♦ entries are always rewards or leverage. See the keystone charters of Ngomebe or the water-share tablets of Fhara.

Cartomancy as Witchcraft

In the Tulkani tradition, cartomancy is not separate from the craft—it *is* the craft. Every reading is a Quick Working, performed at a threshold (the table, the crossroads, the moment between decisions). The cards are the tools; the reader is the witness.

The Three Layers of Reading

Like all witchcraft, cartomancy operates across the three Concordant Layers:

- **Echo (What Has Been):** The cards reveal the accumulated weight of past decisions. A ♠ from Echo shows the history of a place; a ♥ from Echo shows a debt that has not yet been paid.
- **Veil (What Is):** The cards show the present moment, the boundary between potential and actual. A ♣ from Veil is a current threat; a ♦ from Veil is an opportunity the party is ignoring.
- **Flow (What Wishes to Be):** The cards reveal the direction of change, the shape of what is coming. A high card from Flow is a promise; a low card is a warning.

The Reader's Price

Every reading exacts a price. The Tulkani say: *“The cards do not give; they lend. And they always collect.”*

When you read the cards, choose one of the Three Prices:

- **Shadow:** You carry the weight of what you have seen. The GM gains 1 SB, which they may spend on a complication tied to the reading.
- **Shame:** The reading reveals something you did not wish to know. You gain a Condition (Guilty, Haunted, or Doubtful) until you act on what you have learned.
- **Identity:** The reading changes you. Mark 1 Identity Strain. You are not quite the same person who sat down at the table.

The Cartomancer's Gift

Once per session, a cartomancer may perform a full reading using the procedure in Section ???. This is a Full Ritual—it requires Significant Time, a witness, and the willingness to pay the price. On a success, the GM must answer one question about the scene, the journey, or the campaign truthfully. On a partial, the answer is cryptic. On a miss, the cards show a false path—the GM gains 2 SB and may introduce a complication.

Rank and Severity: The Weight of the Card

The rank of a card—from Ace (high) to 2 (low)—sets the scale of its suit's meaning. In the Tulkani tradition, we say: *“The rank is the breath; the suit is the voice. A high breath speaks louder; a low breath is a whisper.”*

Rank	Narrative Weight
Ace	Legendary, campaign-altering, mythic
King/Queen/Jack	Major, faction-level, lasting consequences
10–7	Significant, scene-defining, costly
6–4	Moderate, manageable, a real cost
3–2	Minor, a complication but not a crisis

When a generator instructs you to set a timer by the highest rank, use this conversion:

- **2–5:** 4-segment timer (short, local problem)

- **6–10:** 6-segment timer (standard, journey-length)
- **J, Q, K:** 8-segment timer (extended, regional problem)
- **A:** 10-segment timer (epic, campaign-length)

Card Faces: The Court as Character

Face cards (Jack, Queen, King) are not merely high ranks. They are *persons* with agency, personality, and often a name. The Tulkani say: “*The court does not sit in judgment of you. You sit in judgment of them.*”

- **Jack:** An agent, a functionary, a messenger. The Jack acts on someone else’s authority. They are competent but replaceable.
- **Queen:** A power in their own right. The Queen has influence, resources, and a network. They are not easily replaced.
- **King:** The ultimate authority in their domain. The King is the source of law, the peak of the hierarchy. To challenge a King is to challenge the order itself.

When a face card appears in a ♡ (actor) draw, give the NPC a name, a motive, and a quirk. When it appears in a ♠ (place) or ♣ (pressure) draw, treat it as a *personified* force: a King of Clubs might be a feud that has lasted generations; a Queen of Spades might be a bridge that remembers every toll.

Aces and the Ninth: The Hollow’s Attention

An Ace is not merely the highest rank. It is a *threshold*. In the Tulkani tradition, we say: “*The Ace is the door that opens when you are not looking. Do not step through it lightly.*”

When an Ace appears in any draw, the Hollow takes notice. The GM gains 1 extra Story Beat (beyond any generated by 1s) to spend on a supernatural complication: a ghostly procession, a bell that rings without a clapper, a shadow that walks independently.

In regions where the Ninth Taboo is strong (Theona, Aelinnel, Ways Between), an Ace may also trigger a specific regional omen. For example:

- In Theona, an Ace of ♠ might add a “missing step” to a bridge.
- In the Ways Between, an Ace of ♡ might cause a reflection to speak.
- In the Mistlands, an Ace of ♣ might cause a bell-line to fail.

The GM should always read an Ace as a signal to escalate the uncanny.

By the Numbers: Procedure for Any Generator

When you sit down to generate a scene, a journey leg, or a settlement, follow this procedure. The Tulkani say: “*The cards are not a script. They are a conversation. Listen to what they tell you, but do not let them speak for you.*”

1. **Name the destination.** Which region? Which route? Which authority controls the gate?
2. **Shuffle and draw.** Draw cards face-up, one for each suit you need. Most generators require all four suits; some (like travel legs) may use only three.
3. **Read the ♠.** This is your place. Describe it first. Set the stage.
4. **Read the ♡.** This is your actor. Introduce them. What do they want? Why are they here?

5. **Read the ♣.** This is your pressure. Complicate the scene. What just went wrong, or what is about to?
6. **Read the ♦.** This is your leverage. What can the players gain if they succeed? Be specific.
7. **Set the timer.** Use the highest rank among the four cards to determine the size of the scene's primary timer (see above).
8. **Interpret faces and Aces.** Give names to face cards. Apply regional Ace effects.
9. **Play to find out.** Use the generated elements as prompts, not scripts. The cards are seeds, not fences.

Regional Flavors: How Suits Shift Meaning

While the core suit meanings remain constant, each region inflects them with its own texture. A ♠ in Ecktoria is a forum or a coin-house; a ♠ in the Valewood is a phasing ruin or a star-road. A ♥ in the Black Banners is a mercenary captain or a condotta broker; a ♥ in Ykrul is a khatun or a bone-singer.

The Tulkani say: *“The same card speaks differently in every land. The fool who reads it the same way twice is a fool twice over.”*

Use the regional chapters as your lexicon. When you draw a card, consult the relevant table. The tables are designed to evoke the specific flavor of the region.

Example: A Draw in Acasia

You are running a journey through the Broken Marches. You draw:

♠ 7, ♥ J, ♣ 4, ♦ Q

1. **♠ 7:** Hill-Motte—Fresh palisade; ditch scattered with caltrops.
2. **♥ J:** Bride with No Dowry but a Claim—Daggers in the wedding chest.
3. **♣ 4:** Wedding Turns Ambush—You are caught between two bloodlines.
4. **♦ Q:** Marriage Proxy—From the Margravine; bind a hill-king to your cause.
5. **Highest rank:** Queen (equivalent to 8). The scene's primary timer is 8 segments: *The Feud Escalates* [8].
6. **Interpretation:** The party arrives at a hill-fort on the eve of a wedding. The bride is caught between two feuding bloodlines. The wedding turns to violence. If the party can survive the ambush and broker peace, the Margravine will grant them a Marriage Proxy—a powerful tool to bind a hill-king to their cause. The 8-segment timer tracks how quickly the feud spirals into open war.

This is the generator at work: four cards, one scene, immediate fiction.

The Unwritten Suit: When a Draw is Incomplete

Sometimes, a generator does not require all four suits. A travel leg may only need ♠, ♥, ♣. A social encounter might only need ♥ and ♣. When a suit is missing, treat its absence as a question:

- **No ♠:** The place is ambiguous, shifting, or hidden. The scene occurs in a liminal space—a crossroads, a fog-bank, a threshold.

- **No ♡:** The actor is absent, silent, or dead. The pressure and place act without a face. This can be more frightening than a named NPC.
- **No ♣:** The scene is calm, peaceful, or mercifully straightforward. This is rare in Fate's Edge. Treasure it.
- **No ♦:** The reward is not a token but an outcome. The players gain Position, information, or a cleared timer rather than a physical asset.

Interpreting Any Draw, Any Region

When you need a prompt in a hurry—a random encounter, a rumor at a tavern, a discovery in a ruin—draw a single card. Use this quick-reference:

♠	A place or landmark. What is its name? What happened here?
♡	A person or faction. What do they want? What do they fear?
♣	A complication or threat. Who or what is the obstacle?
♦	A reward, token, or secret. What can be gained?

The rank tells you the scale. A low rank is local and personal; a high rank is regional and political. A face card demands a name; an Ace demands the Hollow's attention.

Tulkani Cartomancy Traditions

The Tulkani have developed specific practices around cartomancy that differ from the regional generators. These are the traditions my grandmother taught me:

The Traveler's Spread (Three Cards)

For a journey, the Tulkani lay three cards:

- **First Card:** The road behind. What have you left behind, and what follows you?
- **Second Card:** The road ahead. What waits for you, and what will you face?
- **Third Card:** The road beneath. What is true, whether you wish it or not?

This spread is a Quick Working; it requires no roll, but the reader must accept the Shadow price.

The Hollow's Spread (Five Cards)

For matters of debt, obligation, or the Hollow's attention, the Tulkani lay five cards:

- **First Card:** The weight you carry.
- **Second Card:** The weight you owe.
- **Third Card:** The weight you have forgotten.
- **Fourth Card:** The weight that carries you.
- **Fifth Card:** The weight that will collect.

This spread is a Full Ritual. It requires Significant Time, a witness, and the acceptance of Identity Strain. On a success, the GM must answer one question about the nature of the debt. On a partial, the answer is cryptic. On a miss, the reader becomes the debt's next collector—a Complication Timer begins.

The Cartomancer's Deck as a Symbol

For Tulkani characters, a cartomancer's deck is a Symbol in the Invoker sense. It is a Minor Asset that grants:

- Access to the cartomancy rituals described above.
- A Patron's Gift (Imbuement) effect: once per scene, the cartomancer may spend an action to draw a card and gain +1 die to a related roll. The GM gains 1 SB.
- Obligation to the Hollow: Each reading marks 1 Obligation, as the cartomancer borrows from the world's memory.

Final Guidance: The Cards Are Oracles, Not Scripts

The generators in this book are tools, not tyrants. If a draw gives you an entry that contradicts established fiction, or if you simply prefer a different interpretation, overrule it. The deck is a prompt, not a prison.

But trust it, too. The most memorable sessions often come from the card you did not expect. The Ace that arrives at the wrong moment. The Jack who speaks a name no one wanted to hear. The diamond that glows with a secret.

The Tulkani say: *"The cards do not lie. But they do not tell the whole truth. The rest is yours to live."*

Shuffle. Draw. Interpret. And let the road unfold.

"The road is never closed. It is only passed to the next walker."

— Mira of the Wandering Circle, on the eve of a journey she did not survive

GM Tools: Using Cartomancy at the Table

Reading the Cards as a GM

The cartomancy framework is designed to be used by GMs, not just players. When you need to generate a scene, a complication, or a reward, draw a card and interpret it through the lens of the region and the current fiction.

Example: The party is in Vhasia, negotiating with a border patrol. You draw a ♣ 9. The entry says: *"Feud Spark—A name spoken wrong reopens an old debt; blood is the only coin that pays."* You interpret this as: the patrol captain's family has a blood feud with one of the party's allies. He recognizes the name and demands a price—either a ransom, a duel, or a favor.

Players as Cartomancers

If a player wants to play a Tulkani cartomancer, use the following framework:

- **Affinity:** Cartomancer's Eye—+1 die to Investigation or Insight rolls involving patterns, hidden connections, or the weight of obligation.
- **Starting Talents:** Cartomancy (4 XP)—grants access to the Traveler's Spread and the Hollow's Spread.
- **Patron:** The Hollow—the cartomancer's Obligation is to the memory of the world itself. The Hollow collects through readings.

The Cost of Cartomancy

Remember: every reading is a transaction. The cards lend, and they collect. A player who reads too often, or who ignores what the cards reveal, will find the Hollow's attention turning their way.

Colophon

This chapter was written in a Tulkani wagon, parked at a crossroads where three roads meet and one does not. The ink is lamp-black and tears. The deck is worn smooth by a hundred thousand shuffles. The ninth card is missing—it always is.

—Mira of the Wandering Circle, in the hour before the ninth bell

For the GM – The Spider, the Snake, the Raven

The three Omens (**Inaea**, **Isoka**, **Ikasha**) are not gods. They are forces that appear in whispers, dreams, and the spaces between counted things. Do not introduce them directly. Instead, let players encounter their echoes:

- A rope that never frays (Inaea)
- A judgment that cuts clean (Isoka)
- A dream that feels too real (Ikasha)

By the time players learn the names, they should have already felt their presence for many sessions.

The full truth of the Omens – the Clockwork Demon, the scouring of civilisations, Ikasha’s imprisonment in Obishaal – is **endgame content**. Use the fragments in this book as breadcrumbs:

- If players ask a Pereshi fire-keeper about the “serpent judge,” they will receive a riddle.
- If they ask a Tulkani about the “dreamer,” they will receive a story.
- If they ask a Sidhi about the “spider,” they will receive a knot and a warning: *“Do not pull it unless you are ready to see what it holds.”*

The Hollow is the interest on the Omens’ oldest debt. The players are never meant to pay it off – only to decide whose name goes on the next line of the ledger.

Part I

The Amaranthine Sea & Northern Shores

“The sea keeps a better ledger than any scribe. The reef remembers every secret whispered above its depths. Do not ask which flag flies highest – ask which hull leaks slowest.” — Dusana of the Raven Road

Chapter 1

Kahfagia

The Flag of Storms.

I was born on the tide, which is to say I was born owing. My mother was a net-mender who lost her fingers to a reef-cutter's debt. My father was a bell—that is to say, he rang when the Admiralty pulled his string. I learned to read the lantern codes before I learned my letters, and I learned that every light is a lie waiting to be told.

The Admiralty runs this place like a pirate charter with a budget—and oh, how they love pretending it's legitimate. They control the beacons that lure ships onto reefs, the booms that shatter hulls for salvage rights, and the tariffs that fund their champagne baths. But here's the secret the commodores don't want you to know: the lanterns are afraid of the dark too.

I've seen a Mirror-Keeper weep when her reflection showed her a daughter she'd sold for a pilot's license. I've watched a Privateer Captain kiss a silver coin before a raid—the same coin her mother kissed before she never came back. This is not a city of heroes. It is a city of people who learned that the sea is cheaper than mercy.

If you want to move cargo through the straits without becoming fish food, get a convoy letter stamped with the Admiral's seal. Or get smart. Or get gone.

— Captain Mira “the Lucky,” Sidhi exile, pirate by convenience

What do people eat for breakfast? Salt fish porridge—dried cod soaked overnight, boiled with hardtack and a splash of lamp oil. The oil is for calories. The fish is for memory. Every Kahfagian child learns to taste the salt and know which coast their grandmother came from.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To count ships by their lanterns. Three lanterns means a Kahfagian merchant—safe. Four means an Oshiiran grain barge—neutral. One,

low in the water, means a privateer. Run.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? *Their hands. Dock-workers have rope-burned palms. Merchants have ink-stained fingers. Privateers have no fingernails—they bite them off in storms.*

What is the most common crime? *False manifests. Every third ship carries cargo that doesn't appear on its papers. The Admiralty knows. The Admiralty takes a cut. The Admiralty calls it a "tariff surcharge."*

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? *The Mirror-Keepers are not born—they are made. And the making requires a death. A sister, a daughter, a lover. Someone who drowned so the keeper could see through the fog.*

Where do people go when they die? *The tide takes them. Kahfagia has no cemeteries above ground. The drowned are weighted with chain and dropped in the deep channel. Their families light candles in paper boats and float them out at dusk. If the candle reaches the horizon, the soul is forgiven. If it sinks, the debt is not yet paid.*

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? *You offer your bell. Every Kahfagian carries a small brass bell on a leather cord—the sound of their name. Offering it to the wronged party means "I give you my voice. Speak for me." Refusing to return the bell after an apology is a declaration of blood feud.*

What is the most important festival? *The Beacon Lighting (midwinter). Every lighthouse keeper lights a new lamp from the Admiral's flame. If your beacon catches first, your year will be lucky. If it sputters, you will owe a death to the sea.*

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? *The Admiral's lantern code has a ninth signal—never used, never spoken, burned into every keeper's memory. It means "Kill the witnesses. Sink the evidence. The sea will hide the rest."*

Part II

The Eastern Dolmis & The Valewood

“Every threshold has a keeper. Some keepers ask for salt. Some ask for silence. The Green Host asks for a name – and it does not mean yours.” — Dusana of the Raven Road

Chapter 2

Theona

Three Greens, No Ninth.

The wells here hold more than water—they hold the dreams and prayers of generations. To govern is to tend these sacred spaces where the living commune with what came before.

I am a Peat-Cutter. My barrow has a false bottom. I hide debts there—and bodies.

The isles of Theona rise green and jagged from the Dolmis, their basalt cliffs wrapped in mists and moorland song. Nominally a duchy sworn to Viterra, in truth the Three Greens heed no crown but their own moots, no law but their taboos. The greatest of these is the silence of Nine: no bell tolls a ninth, no bridge counts that span, no oath dares its syllable.

The Viterran sheriffs call it superstition. The Green Host calls it trespass. The difference is that the sheriffs will hang you. The Green Host will take your name, and you will wander the mist until you forget you ever had one.

Never pour the ninth cup at a feast. Never speak the ninth name in a bargain. Never step where a step is missing. The Green Host rides for those who complete what should remain incomplete.

— *Celia, Hedge-Witch Midwife, who has tied nine thousand knots and untied nine*

What do people eat for breakfast? Oatcakes and heather ale—the oats are grown on terraced hillsides, the heather is harvested from the high moors. The ale is brewed in secret, by women who have forgotten more recipes than the men will ever learn. The men do not ask. The men are wise.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To count to eight. Theona children are taught numbers on their fingers—eight fingers, two thumbs. The thumbs are not counted. The thumbs are for pointing. Pointing is for warnings. Warnings are for the ninth thing.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? *Their shadow. Theona is a land of mists and twilight. A stranger whose shadow is too short has been touched by the Host. A stranger whose shadow is too long is running from them. A stranger with no shadow is already taken. Do not speak to them. Do not meet their eyes. Do not offer them salt.*

What is the most common crime? *Breaking the ninth taboo—but breaking the taboo is not a crime, it is an invitation. The Host rides for those who pour the ninth cup, speak the ninth name, or take the ninth step. The Host does not arrest. The Host takes. The taken are never found. Their empty cups remain on the table. The cups are warm for three days.*

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? *The Green Host are not ghosts. They are the living—Theonans who broke the taboo and were taken. They ride with the King in Green, who was once a chieftain of the northern isle. He broke the ninth vow. He was not taken. He was crowned. His crown is made of thorns. His throne is a barrow. His court is the mist.*

Where do people go when they die? *To the barrows. Theona's dead are buried in long, low mounds that line the eastern cliffs. The mounds are planted with gorse and broom. The gorse blooms yellow in spring. The yellow is for mourning. The broom is for memory. The dead are not mourned. The dead are remembered. Remembering is enough.*

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? *You walk the Ninth Mile—a stretch of road that circles the central isle. The road is nine miles long. You must walk it at night, alone, with no light. If you reach the end by dawn, you are forgiven. If you do not, the Host will find you. The Host is always looking. The Host is always waiting.*

What is the most important festival? *The Feast of the Eighth Cup (autumn equinox). Every household pours eight cups of mead—one for each of the living generations. The ninth cup is poured onto the ground. The ground drinks. The ancestors listen. The ancestors do not answer.*

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? *The Three-Isles King is a changeling. The real king died in 798 AR, drowned in a peat bog while hunting. The changeling was placed by the Lady Beneath as part of a bargain. The bargain was for peace between the isles. The peace has held. The changeling has aged. The changeling's reflection does not.*

Part III

The Southern Realms (Akilan)

“The ledger does not forgive arithmetic errors. A single miscounted bushel can unmake a house, a tribe, an empire. I am not here to be kind. I am here to be correct. But even the Widow’s ink runs when the monsoon weeps.” — Dusana of the Raven Road, at the weigh-house of Mbaro

Chapter 3

Oshiira

The Ledger Empire.

The ledger does not forgive arithmetic errors. A single miscounted bushel can unmake a house, a tribe, an empire. I am not here to be kind. I am here to be correct.

I am a Grain Inspector. My stamp leaves a mark that glows under moonlight. I know.

Oshiira is a confederacy of hundreds of tribes and city-states, united by the Grain Ledger. The capital, Mbaro, is a city of canals, weigh-houses, and the great Granary Tower. Oshiira is the breadbasket of the Amaranthine; its millet and sorghum fill the holds of Ecktorian, Vhasian, and Silkstrand ships. The empire operates through a bureaucracy as complex as any in the north—weighing-houses, canal-mothers, and ledgers that track every grain shipment with mathematical precision. But here's the secret the Widow doesn't want you to know: the Ledger has a page that has been torn out. That page named the true heir. No one knows where it is. Everyone is looking.

The Vermilion Corps audits not only grain but also loyalty. The Narrow Captains provoke Kahfagia just to remind the Admiralty who really controls the straits. And the Widow—the empress who has held the confederacy together for centuries—is dying. Paranoia is slowly replacing wisdom. Her four children circle the throne like vultures. The Vermilion Corps maintains order, but no one knows which heir the Corps truly serves. Not even the Corps itself.

Never speak of succession before naming the Widow. The empress's health is a state secret, and the Vermilion Corps has ears in every weigh-house. Speak carelessly, and your name may be the next one erased from the Ledger.

— *Vermilion Corps Auditor, who counts her own breaths to ensure she is not lying*

What do people eat for breakfast? Millet porridge with dried fish—the millet is grown in the flood plains of the Sahel, the fish is smoked over canal-barges. The porridge is always the same. The fish varies by season. The seasons are measured by the height of the river. The river is the Widow's blood. The Widow's blood is low.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To weigh a grain. Oshiira children are given a balance scale and a single grain of millet. By age five, they can tell you the weight difference between a grain harvested in the northern Sahel and a grain harvested in the southern riverlands. The difference is the tax. The tax feeds the empire. The empire is hungry.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their hands. Oshiira merchants have ink-stained fingers—the ink is from the Ledger. A stranger whose fingers are clean has never signed a contract. A stranger whose fingers are stained black has signed too many. A stranger whose fingers are stained red has signed a death warrant. The red ink is not ink. The red ink is blood.

What is the most common crime? Ledger fraud—but ledger fraud is not a crime, it is a career. The Vermilion Corps audits the auditors. The auditors audit the clerks. The clerks audit the merchants. The merchants audit the farmers. The farmers audit the land. The land does not lie. The land does not need to.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Widow has not been seen in public for seven years. Her voice is a recording. Her seal is a stamp. Her decrees are written by the Vermilion Corps. The Corps signs in her name. The Corps speaks in her voice. The Corps is the Widow. The Widow is dead. The empire continues.

Where do people go when they die? To the Granary Tower—the great stone silo at the center of Mbaro. The dead are not buried. They are ground into meal and mixed with the millet. The grain is shipped across the Amaranthine. The dead feed the empire. The empire does not know. The empire does not ask.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You submit a correction to the Ledger. The correction must be witnessed by a Vermilion Corps auditor. The auditor stamps the correction with their seal. The seal glows under moonlight. The moonlight is the Widow's eye. The Widow sees everything. The Widow forgives nothing.

What is the most important festival? The Harvest of the Ledger (autumn). The Ledger is opened in the great square. The names of the year's debtors are read aloud. The debtors are given until dawn to pay. The debtors who cannot pay are added to the Ledger's ninth page. The ninth page is sealed with wax. The wax is black. The black is mourning.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Ledger's missing page is not missing. It was burned by the Widow herself, in the year the last heir died. The page's ash was mixed into the mortar of the Granary Tower. The ash still glows under moonlight. The glow spells the heir's name. The name is the Widow's own. The Widow killed her child. The empire does not know. The empire would not care.

Part IV

The Way of Silk

“The road is a ledger. Every oasis is a credit, every broken wheel a debt. The Tulkani tie knots to remember who owes whom. The Fhara weigh water before they weigh silver. The Pereshi recite verses to keep the bridges open. And the Sidhi keep lighthouse lamps burning for the dead who still have not reached the shore.” — Dusana of the Raven Road, at a caravanserai whose name she refused to give

Chapter 4

Fhara

The Oasis Courts.

Water is not a right. It is a loan from the sand. The oasis remembers every drop drawn, every cup poured, every promise made at its edge. I do not judge the living. I judge the debt.

I am a Water-Clerk. My grandfather dug this well with a shovel and a prayer. My mother sealed the walls with clay from the dry river. I sit in the shade and measure every bucket. The sand does not forgive a miscount.

Water isn't just law in Fhara—it's a market, and oh, how the water-clerks love a good deal on aquifer access. They don't just negotiate in three cups; they auction the right to the fourth cup. The Fhara are merchants, poets, and negotiators; they will bargain for an hour over a cup of coffee, and a day over a camel. But here's the secret the well-judges don't want you to know: the wells have ears. Every cup poured, every promise made at the edge, every drop drawn—the well-spirits are listening. And they have opinions. They favor the generous. They punish the greedy. And they never, ever forget a face.

The Fhara have no single king. Their confederacy is a web of marriage alliances, water-sharing treaties, and caravan tariffs. The desert is not empty—it is a ledger of dry wells, abandoned caravanserais, and the bones of those who could not share. A Fhara merchant can cross the waste with only a waterskin and a coffee pot, because every well has a keeper, every keeper a price, and every price can be negotiated. But the negotiation is a ritual. Three cups: the first is welcome, the second is bargaining, the third is a contract. Refuse the third, and you have broken an oath. The well-spirit will remember.

Never refuse a date offered by a well-keeper. The fruit is sacred to their

well-spirits. Refusing it ends the conversation—and your access to water.

— *Well-Judge Fatima al-Wadi, who carries a dipper made from a date-palm leaf that rots after each case*

What do people eat for breakfast? Dates and thin coffee—the dates are from the well-keepers' groves, the coffee is brewed with cardamom and camel milk. The milk is sour. The sourness is for endurance.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To count cups. Fhara children are taught the eight cups of negotiation: Welcome, Bargain, Contract, Witness, Debt, Payment, Forgiveness, and the ninth—the cup that is never poured. The ninth cup is for the well-spirit. The well-spirit is always thirsty.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their water-skin. A stranger whose water-skin is full has not traveled far. A stranger whose water-skin is dry has traveled too far. A stranger who carries no water-skin is either a well-keeper or a fool. Well-keepers are honoured. Fools are buried.

What is the most common crime? Water theft—but water theft is not a crime, it is a declaration of feud. The well-spirit records every theft in the aquifer. The aquifer is the court. The judge is the well. The verdict is thirst.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The wells are not natural. They were carved by the first Fhara, who made a bargain with the sand. The bargain was for water. The price was memory. The Fhara remember everything. They cannot forget. That is the curse of the wells.

Where do people go when they die? To the oasis. The dead are buried in the date groves, their graves marked with a single stone. The stone is not carved. The dead's name is spoken at sunrise. If the name is remembered, the dead rests. If it is forgotten, the dead walks.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a cup—the ninth cup, poured from your own water-skin. The cup is placed at the well's edge. If the well-spirit drinks, you are forgiven. If the water evaporates, you are not. If the cup cracks, your debt is doubled.

What is the most important festival? The Filling of the Wells (spring). Every well is cleaned and blessed. The water-clerks recite the names of the year's debtors. The debtors stand at the water's edge. If their reflection wavers, they are forgiven. If it holds, they must pay.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The water-clerks' ledger is a forgery. The original was lost in a sandstorm three generations ago. The clerks have been inventing water rights ever since. The wells do not care. The wells remember the original. The wells are waiting.

Part V

Dhahara — The Kingdom of Brass

“The mountain weighs every breath, every ingot, every oath. Pay in iron, pay in silence, or pay in blood. And when the ninth lease cracks, even the elephants will remember who fed them during the famine.” —
Dusana of the Raven Road, at the Viceroy’s Hall in Sarvistan

Chapter 5

The Brass Coast

Shore of Silver and Spice.

"The tariff is the law. The law is the tariff. I do not care if your goods are stolen, blessed, or weeping. I care that you pay. The Admiralty does not rule this coast. The ledger rules. I am merely its pen."

I am a spice merchant, grandson of a raja who watched the first Kahfagian customs house rise on our beach. The Admiralty calls me a subject. The Sidhi call me a partner. I call myself a son of the Brass Coast. My grandfather's sword hangs above my desk. One day, I may need it again. The sword has nine notches. Each notch is a promise the Admiralty broke.

The Brass Coast is Dhahara's southern rim: a humid, feverish coastline of palm groves, salt pans, and crowded port cities. The Kahfagian Admiralty administers it as a "client province," but three powers bleed into each other here, and none can draw a clean breath. The Admiralty holds the ports and the tariff ledgers. The Sidhi diaspora runs the ropeways, the lighthouse courts, and the freedman's seal. And the native Dhaharan rajas — the hill lords who have lived here since before any foreign flag flew — grow the pepper, mine the iron, and watch the coast from inland fortresses, waiting.

Here, a man can buy anything — a ship, a spice lot, a freedman's seal — and sell anything except his own shadow. The Admiralty's Maritime Court settles disputes with a judge's gavel and a marine's cutlass. The Sidhi lighthouse courts offer an alternative: justice by green flame, witnessed by the drowned. And the rajas enforce their own law in the hills, where the Admiralty's writ does not run. But here's the secret the Admiralty doesn't want you to know: the ropeways that carry spice baskets from ship to warehouse are old, and the dead still pull their weight — not just Sidhi dead, but the drowned of every

nation who could not pay their passage. The coast remembers them all. The ninth rope on every ropeway is always frayed. No one replaces it. That rope carries the debt.

Never board a ship that has a green lantern at the mast. It means the captain is under a death vow — and you are the payment. If the lantern burns blue, run. The blue flame is the Admiral's oracle, and she does not make bargains.

— *Raja Govind of the Kalinga foothills, who has never seen the sea and refuses to start*

What do people eat for breakfast? Rice and fermented fish paste — the rice is grown in coastal paddies, the fish is caught by the lighthouse keepers' children. The children are paid in copper. The copper is melted into seals. The seals are sold to whoever can afford them. The ninth child never takes payment. No one knows why.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To read a lighthouse code. Brass Coast children are taught the eight lamp-flashes: Tariff, Inspection, Quarantine, Smuggler, Pirate, Rescue, Home, and the ninth — the flash that means "the collector is coming." The ninth flash is never used. The ninth flash is a warning. The children learn it anyway.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their papers. The Admiralty requires a manifest for every shipment, a seal for every trader, a stamp for every dock. A stranger whose papers are in order is a merchant. A stranger whose papers are missing is a smuggler. A stranger whose papers are too perfect is a spy. The spies are Admiralty. The Admiralty spies on itself. The ninth page of every manifest is always blank. That is where the dead travel.

What is the most common crime? Tariff evasion — but tariff evasion is not a crime, it is a profession. The tariffs are set by the Admiralty. The Admiralty is corrupt. The evaders pay the Admiralty directly. The payment is called a "consulting fee." The fee is tax-deductible. The ninth fee is always paid in salt, not silver. The salt comes from the Freedman's Grave.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The lighthouse lamps are not fuelled by oil. They are fuelled by the fat of the drowned — whales, sailors, slaves who did not survive the crossing. The fat burns green. The green is the color of memory. The memory is the dead's. The ninth lamp on every tower is never lit. It is reserved for the collector.

Where do people go when they die? To the sea. The dead are weighted with brass and dropped in the deep channel. The channel is called the Freedman's Grave, but it holds rajas and pirates alike. The grave is unmarked. The grave is the entire coast. The ninth body dropped each year is never weighted. It floats. It always drifts toward the Admiral's palace.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a tariff — a payment of silver, calculated by the wronged party's estimate of their loss. The tariff is paid to the Maritime Court. The court takes a percentage. The percentage is the judge's fee. The judge's fee is negotiable. The ninth tariff ever collected was paid in a memory. The judge still remembers it. He wishes he did not.

What is the most important festival? The Burning of the Ledgers (new year). Every merchant's ledger is brought to the lighthouse. The ledgers are read aloud. The debts are tallied. The ledgers are burned. The ash falls on the water. The water carries the debts to the sea. The sea does not forgive. The sea reschedules. The ninth ledger is never burned. It is kept in a brass box at the bottom of the Freedman's Grave. It contains the Admiralty's own debts.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The lighthouse lamps are not all green. One lamp burns blue — the Admiral's personal beacon. The blue flame is not fat. It is a spirit — a

Sidhi oracle who was bound to the lighthouse nine generations ago. She sees everything. She speaks to no one. The Admiral does not know she is still alive. Her ninth prophecy was never recorded. It said: "The collector will come by sea, and the ledger will burn from the bottom up."

Part VI

The Eastern Realms

“The maps of the empire draw the East as a single sweep – Sihai, Nihori, Ayokha – all pressed together like tiles on a game board. The roads know better. Sihai measures time in dynasties; Nihori counts it in storms. Ayokha negotiates between them with the patience of the monsoon. And beneath them all, the older peoples keep their own thresholds, their own debts, their own ways of not being seen.” — Dusana of the Raven Road, at the edge of the Inland Sea

Chapter 6

Sihai

The Central Kingdom.

The Mandate of Heaven is not a right. It is a loan. The emperor borrows legitimacy from the ancestors, from the land, from the Hollow itself. When the loan is due, the empire falls. I do not serve the emperor. I serve the ledger that tracks the interest.

I am a Provincial Censor. My brush is heavier than any sword. A single stroke can erase a name, a family, a dynasty. The emperor reads my reports and trembles. He knows that I have written nine reports this year. The ninth is about him.

Sihai is the central kingdom, the seat of the Emperor and the Mandate of Heaven. Its canals carry grain from the south; its examination halls produce bureaucrats who govern by the brush. Power here is measured in ink, not iron. The Censorate watches everyone; the Salt Monopoly controls trade; the Lethai-thora keep the secrets that the Mandate prefers to forget. But here's the secret the Emperor doesn't want you to know: the Mandate is not a divine right. It is a loan. The ancestors are the creditors. The Hollow collects the interest. Every dynasty that has ever fallen did so because the interest came due and the emperor could not pay.

Beneath the mortal bureaucracy runs a deeper one: the Celestial Bureaucracy of gods, ghosts, and ancestors, where every official has a heavenly counterpart and every erased name becomes a hungry ghost. The Lethai-thora—the ancient archivists who taught the first emperors to write—still keep the hidden ledgers, the ones that record what the Censorate burns. A well-written couplet can appease a ghost; a forged seal can summon a demon. The Hollow's ninth debt is the unpaid interest on the Mandate itself.

Never speak of succession before naming the Emperor. The Censorate has ears in every tea house. A misplaced word can erase your name from the rolls.

— *Quiet Chancellor Wei, who has never smiled and whose seal is a laughing mouth*

What do people eat for breakfast? Congee with preserved vegetables—the congee is rice boiled until it is memory, the vegetables are salted and aged in clay jars. The jars are sealed with the emperor's own wax. The wax is a promise. The promise is that the vegetables will not poison you. The promise is sometimes broken.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To write their name. Sihai children are taught the eight strokes of the character “person”—the ninth stroke is the one that turns a name into a signature. A signature is a contract. A contract is a debt. A debt is a life.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their chop—the seal they carry to sign documents. A stranger whose chop is jade is a noble. A stranger whose chop is brass is a clerk. A stranger whose chop is wood is a merchant. A stranger with no chop is a ghost. Ghosts cannot sign contracts. Ghosts cannot be trusted.

What is the most common crime? Examination fraud—but fraud is not a crime, it is a family business. The examinations determine who governs. The questions are leaked in advance. The answers are memorized. The examiners are bribed. The system is a sieve. The sieve is called “merit.”

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Emperor is a figurehead. The real power is the Censorate—nine ministers who have never been seen together. Their names are not recorded. Their faces are not painted. Their orders are whispered. The Emperor signs what they tell him to sign. The Emperor has not refused in forty years.

Where do people go when they die? To the ancestral tablets. The dead are not buried. Their names are written on wooden tablets, placed in the family shrine. The tablets are fed with rice and tea. The dead eat the steam. The dead are never full.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a calligraphy—a scroll written in your own blood. The scroll is presented to the wronged party's ancestral shrine. If the ancestors accept, you are forgiven. If the scroll bursts into flame, you are not. If the scroll writes itself, the ancestors are angry. The ancestors' anger is a famine.

What is the most important festival? The Festival of the Ancestors (autumn). The tablets are cleaned and polished. The dead are invited to feast. The feast is laid out on the family altar. The food is removed after an hour. The dead have eaten the essence. The essence is memory.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Censorate's ninth minister is a woman—the emperor's own mother, who was supposed to have died in childbirth. She faked her death to escape the politics of the court. She has been running the Censorate from a hidden villa in the western hills. The emperor does not know. The emperor's mother signs his death warrants. He signs them too.

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6.1 Sihai — “The Central Kingdom”

Key Demographics: Humans **Capital City:** Jingdu

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The Mandate is a memory. The ancestors are listening. The Hollow collects what is forgotten.*

Quiet Chancellor (Elite): “The Mandate of Heaven is not a right. It is a story we tell ourselves — that the emperor remembers the names of the dead. When the story falters, the empire falls. I do not serve the emperor. I serve the silence where the forgotten names should be.”

Provincial Censor (Commoner): “My brush is heavier than any sword. A single stroke can make a name vanish — from ledgers, from lips, from the dreams of those who loved it. The emperor reads my reports and trembles. He knows that I have written nine reports this year. The ninth is about him.”

Genre / Mood: Celestial bureaucracy, ink-washed horror, examination hell, the weight of forgotten ancestors.

Starting Location: An examination hall where ink-stained desks face a silent proctor. A Provincial Censor holds up a scroll: “This candidate’s family name has been erased. He does not know. You will tell him — or you will take his place in the silence.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Sihai is the central kingdom, the seat of the Emperor and the Mandate of Heaven. Its canals carry grain from the south; its examination halls produce bureaucrats who govern by the brush. But beneath the mortal bureaucracy runs a deeper one: the Celestial Bureaucracy of gods, ghosts, and ancestors, where every official has a heavenly counterpart and every erased name becomes a hungry ghost. The Lethai-thora — the ancient archivists who taught the first emperors to write — still keep the hidden scrolls, the ones that record what the Censorate burns.

Power here is measured in ink, not iron. The Censorate watches everyone; the Salt Monopoly controls trade; the Kitchen God reports every household’s secrets to the Jade Emperor at New Year. A well-written couplet can appease a ghost; a forged seal can summon a demon. The Hollow’s ninth weight is the silence at the heart of the Mandate itself. Every dynasty inherits its legitimacy; every silence is a weight.

What you notice first: The smell of ink and canal water, but also incense and grave-soil. The way officials stamp every document with a brass seal — and the way the seal leaves a faint watermark that looks like a face. The constant ticking of water-timers, but sometimes the ticking skips a beat, and the shadows pause to listen.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never speak of succession before naming the Emperor. The Censorate has ears in every tea house — and the ghosts have ears in every wall. A misplaced word can make a name vanish from the rolls, and from the memory of the ancestors.

Regional Mood: The Weight of the Brush

Power here is measured in examination scores, salt licenses, and the thickness of a family's archive. The Emperor rules, but the Censorate audits, the Salt Monopoly finances, and the Lethai-thora remember what the Censorate burns. A provincial governor's authority rests on his examination rank; a merchant's on his salt license. The dead are not gone — they are merely demoted. The Hungry Ghost Festival is the only time the Celestial Bureaucracy accepts appeals. The Hollow watches from the missing ninth step, the unpoured ninth cup, the unsaid ninth name.

Prominent NPCs of Sihai

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumored Quirk
Quiet Chancellor Wei	Imperial censor	Root out corruption before the Mandate fails	He has never smiled. His seal is a laughing mouth. He speaks to the Kitchen God each evening.
Salt Commissioner Li	Head of the Salt Monopoly	Control the price of salt and the flow of silver	She tastes every batch of salt before it is stamped. Her tongue is white. She sees ghosts in the brine.
Provincial Censor Chen	Overseer of the eastern prefectures	Erase a rebel lineage from the rolls	He writes with his left hand. His right hand is for swearing oaths. His left hand has no fingerprints.
Lethai-thora Keeper Lian	Hidden archivist	Protect a scroll that proves the emperor's claim is false	She has not spoken aloud in twenty years. She writes on water. The water never freezes.

The Hollow’s Oath-Keeper	Spirit of the fractured Mandate	Collect the ninth name, the ninth step, the ninth cup	It appears as a scribe with too many fingers. It never blinks. It smells of old incense.
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Names of Sihai

Inspired by the central kingdom: short, tonal, with honorifics. Surnames often denote a clan or a prefecture.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Clan/House	Epithets
Wei	Lian	Chen	<i>the Quiet</i>
Li	Mei	Zhou	<i>Salt-Tongue</i>
Chen	Huan	Zhao	<i>the Unerased</i>
Zhang	Ning	Wu	<i>Ninth Seal</i>
Liu	Ping	Tang	<i>the Brush</i>

(Hall/Canal/Archive) Examination hall with ink-stained desks; Grand Canal lock with barges queueing; Lethai-thora hidden archive behind a waterfall.

Spades — Places

- Examination Hall (Hell of Ink)** — A long building with ink-stained desks, silent proctors, and a single bell. *The bell rings when a candidate cheats. It rings once a day on average. The ghosts of failed candidates write answers on the ceiling.* [DEATH]
- Grand Canal Lock (Dragon Gate)** — A stone gate where barges queue for inspection. Officials stamp manifests. *The stamp leaves a watermark that glows under moonlight — a dragon scale. Forgeries are obvious. The dragon knows.* [MAGIC]
- Lethai-thora Hidden Archive** — A pavilion behind a waterfall, filled with forbidden scrolls. *The scrolls are sealed with silk cords. The cords have nine knots. The ninth is a lie. The archivists are all ghosts.* [SECRET]
- Salt Commissioner’s Counting House** — A fortress of ledgers, guarded by armed clerks. *The ledgers are written in disappearing ink. Only the Commissioner knows the reagent — tears of a famine widow.* [AUTHORITY]
- Provincial Censorate Office** — A gray building with a brass scale above the door. *The scale weighs truth and lies. It has never balanced. When it tips, someone is erased.* [JUSTICE]
- Emperor’s Forbidden Garden (Kunlun Pavilion)** — A walled garden where no one may enter without permission. *The garden contains a single tree with nine branches. The ninth branch is dead. A phoenix nests in the eighth.* [MYTH]
- Well of Erased Names** — A stone well where the Censorate throws scrolls of erased lineages. *The scrolls burn as they fall. The smoke smells of ink and old blood. The well is bottomless.* [DEATH]

9. **Tea House of the Ninth Cup (Ghost Festival)** — A popular establishment where the ninth cup is never poured. *The owner has a bell that rings when someone pours the ninth cup. It rings often. The ring attracts hungry ghosts.* [SOCIAL]
10. **Canal Mother's Court** — A shaded bench where water rights are assigned. *The bench is carved with the names of every canal mother for nine generations. The ninth name is blank. It waits.* [COMMUNITY]



The Emperor's Tomb (Unfinished) — A subterranean complex where the current emperor's tomb is being built. *The workers are slaves. They will be buried with him. They know. They carve their names into the walls.* [DEATH]



The Hollow's Gate (Subterranean) — A crack in the floor of the Forbidden Garden. *The crack is warm. It whispers the names of emperors who died without heirs. The names are getting longer.* [MYSTERY]



The Ninth Ledger's Vault — A vault beneath the Counting House, accessible only by nine keys. *The ninth key is held by the Hollow. The Hollow will surrender it — for a price. The price is a name you have never spoken.* [WEIGHT]



The First Examination Hall (Myth) — Where the first emperor tested his sons. *The hall is invisible. Only those who have passed nine examinations can see it. Inside, the first emperor still grades papers.* [LEGEND]

(**Censor/Merchant/Keeper**) Provincial censor with a list of forbidden words; salt merchant with honest scales except when they aren't; Lethai-thora memory-keeper with a silence-token.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Provincial Censor** — Gray-robed, a brass seal on a chain. He carries a list of forbidden words. *"Speak the ninth word," he says, "and your name will join the list." The list is written on human skin.* [AUTHORITY]
3. **Salt Merchant** — A thin woman with a brass scale. Her weights are hollow. *"The scale is honest," she says. "My hand is not." She has nine weights. The ninth is empty.* [TRADE]
4. **Lethai-thora Keeper** — Silent, carrying a brass lamp. She writes on water with a reed brush. *"The words vanish," she says. "That is how I know they are true." Her lamp burns without oil.* [SECRET]
5. **Canal Mother** — A matriarch in blue robes, a key to the sluice gate on her belt. *"Water is memory," she says. "The canal remembers every bribe." She has never taken a bribe. She has taken nine stories.* [COMMUNITY]
6. **Examination Candidate** — A young man with ink-stained fingers. He has failed nine times. *"The tenth will be different," he says. He has said this nine times. His shadow is missing two fingers.* [DESPERATION]
7. **Quiet Chancellor's Spy** — A woman disguised as a tea-seller. She listens at every table. *She writes reports on her own skin. The ink is invisible. Her skin is full. She is running out of space.* [STEALTH]
8. **Salt Worker (Slave)** — A man with cracked hands, harvesting salt from pans. *"The salt tastes of tears," he says. "Whose tears, I do not know." He is bound to nine years of labor. He has served eight.* [LABOR]

9. **Hollow’s Oath-Keeper** — A tall figure in gray, with too many fingers. It carries a ledger. *It asks: “Where is the ninth name?” It will not leave without an answer. Its ledger is made of human bone.* [DEATH]
10. **Emperor’s Dreamer** — A woman locked in a tower. She dreams the emperor’s nightmares. *She wakes screaming. The dreams are always about the Hollow. She has not dreamed in nine days. The emperor has not slept.* [MYSTERY]



The First Censor (Ghost) — A skeleton in gray robes, sitting in the Well of Erased Names. *He asks: “Did I erase the right name?” The answer is always a lie. He knows. He asks anyway.* [DEATH]



Canal Mother’s Ghost — A translucent figure walking the canal at midnight. *She checks the water level. When it drops, a reckoning is due. She carries a dipper that never empties.* [COMMUNITY]



The Ninth Emperor’s Ghost — A crowned skeleton in the unfinished tomb. *He asks: “Is the Mandate renewed?” If you say no, he weeps. His tears turn to ink. The ink writes new laws.* [LEGEND]



Kuva’s Shadow (Hollow) — The vast darkness that covers the Forbidden Garden at midnight. *It asks: “Who holds the ninth key?” The answer is a name no one knows. The darkness absorbs the answer.* [PATRON]

(Forgery/Monsoon/Ancestor) A scroll is found to be a forgery — the party is blamed; monsoon breaks early — the canal closes; an ancestor demands a public accounting of a forgotten burden.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Forged Scroll** — A tax ledger is discovered to be a fake. The forgery is perfect. *The forger is a Censorate clerk. The scroll is not a forgery — it is the original. The Censorate has been lying for centuries.* [DECEPTION]
3. **Monsoon Breaks Early** — The canal closes for inspection. Delay 2 segments. *The closure is a cover. The Censorate is searching for a specific barge. The barge carries a forbidden ancestor tablet.* [WEATHER]
4. **Ancestor’s Demand** — A ghost appears at the family shrine. It demands a public accounting. *The obligation is from nine generations ago. The ancestor will not leave until it is settled. It will accept a story if the story is true.* [DEATH]
5. **Censorate Audit** — Officials arrive with a warrant. They have a list of forbidden words. *The list includes a word you spoke yesterday. The penalty is erasure. The word was your grandmother’s name.* [AUTHORITY]
6. **Salt Monopoly Price Hike** — The Commissioner doubles the salt tax. Riots begin. *The hike is a bribe. The bribe is to the Quiet Chancellor. He accepted. The salt is now gray. It used to be white.* [TRADE]
7. **Canal Lock Sabotage** — Someone drops a barge at the lock. The canal backs up. *The saboteur is a Canal Mother’s son. He wants to flood the Censorate office. The water is rising. The papers are drowning.* [DISASTER]
8. **Examination Cheating Scandal** — A candidate is caught with a cheat sheet. The sheet has your name. *The cheat sheet was planted. The real target is your patron. The cheat sheet is*

written in disappearing ink. It will be gone by dawn. [TRAP]

9. **Lethai-thora Archive Fire** — A lamp falls in the hidden pavilion. Scrolls burn. *The fire was set by the Censorate. They want to erase a specific history. The history is about the first emperor's true lineage. [DESTRUCTION]*
10. **Hollow's Weight Called** — An Oath-Keeper appears at the tea house. It points at a party member. *A burden has found its bearer. The burden is the ninth cup. Settle it in story or memory. The Oath-Keeper will know if you lie. [WEIGHT]*



Emperor's Health Fails — The Mandate wavers. Succession rumors spike. *The emperor has no heir. The Hollow is watching. It will claim the ninth name. The name is the emperor's. He does not know it. [POLITICS]*



Forbidden Garden Breached — Someone enters the garden without permission. The Hollow follows. *The intruder is a child. The Hollow asks: "Why are you here?" The child does not know. The child is a ghost. It has been dead for nine years. [MYSTERY]*



Ninth Ledger Stolen — The vault is cracked. The ninth ledger is missing. *The ledger contains the names of everyone the Censorate has erased. The thief is a ghost. The ghost is the first emperor. He wants his name back. [DEATH]*



Mandate Falls — The emperor dies without an heir. The Hollow claims the throne. *The Hollow sits on the dragon throne. It asks: "Who will rule?" Silence is the only answer. The Hollow begins to write. [APOCALYPSE]*

(Pass/Seal/Token) Stamped pass from a provincial governor (one use); copy of the Celestial Ledger (reveals one hidden tax); Lethai-thora silence-token (one question the keeper must answer).

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Stamped Pass (Governor's Seal)** — A wax-sealed document. Grants passage through any provincial checkpoint. *The seal is a tiger. It glows when a Censorate agent is nearby. The tiger's eyes follow you. [TRAVEL]*
3. **Celestial Ledger (Copy)** — A scroll containing one hidden tax. Use it to blackmail an official. *The ledger is written in disappearing ink. Read it aloud before it fades. The ink tastes of copper. [BLACKMAIL]*
4. **Lethai-thora Silence-Token** — A brass charm. Present it to demand a keeper answer one question. *The keeper cannot lie. The question must be about a forgotten secret. The secret is never small. [SOCIAL]*
5. **Junk Seal (Official)** — A brass seal. Impersonate a provincial official for one scene. *The seal is warm. It glows when someone tests its authenticity. The glow is the color of a lie. [DECEPTION]*
6. **Canal Mother's Key** — A bronze key. Open any sluice gate in the Grand Canal. *The key is cold. It warms when a water right is being violated. The warmth is the temperature of a drowning. [AUTHORITY]*
7. **Salt Commissioner's Waiver** — A stamped document. Exempts you from the salt tax for one year. *The waiver is written on silk. The silk was stolen from the Commissioner's own robes. The thread is from a noose. [TRADE]*
8. **Examination Answer Key (Forged)** — A cheat sheet that actually works. Pass one examination automatically. *The answers are written in invisible ink. The reagent is moonlight. The*

answers are wrong — but the examiners cannot tell. [DECEPTION]

9. **Quiet Chancellor’s Seal (Jade)** — A jade seal. Commands the Censorate to ignore one crime. *The seal is a forgery. The Chancellor made it himself. It still works. The jade is warm. It was cut from a tomb.* [AUTHORITY]
10. **Forbidden Garden Key (Iron)** — A heavy iron key. Opens the gate to the Emperor’s garden. *The key is cursed. Each use ages the wielder one month. The key does not care. It has been waiting for centuries.* [MYSTERY]

 **Hollow’s Ninth Ledger Page** — A single page from the ninth ledger. Contains nine erased names. *Speak a name, and that person’s deeds become known. The Hollow will remember too. The page is warm. It has a pulse.* [DEATH]

 **First Censor’s Brush** — A brush made from a phoenix feather. Write any name, and it is erased from all records. *The brush works once. Then it crumbles. The Hollow will know. The phoenix will not forgive.* [LEGEND]

 **Canal Mother’s Ghostly Dipper** — A clay dipper used by a dead Canal Mother. Use it to control any sluice gate. *The dipper is cold. It weeps water when a reckoning is due. The water is salt. It tastes of old grief.* [COMMUNITY]

 **The Mandate Itself (Scroll)** — A scroll that proves the current emperor has no legitimate claim. *Read it aloud, and the Mandate falls. The Hollow will take the throne. The scroll burns after reading. The smoke is a new name.* [APOCALYPSE]

Censorate Audit Complications (d6)

When a character faces a Censorate audit (see Additional Features), roll or choose an additional complication that escalates the stakes.

d6	Complication
1	Erased Name — The Censorate has struck your name from a ledger. You are legally invisible. Gain –1 Position on all social rolls with officials until resolved.
2	Ancestor Summons — A ghost appears at the family shrine demanding a public accounting. The burden is from nine generations ago.
3	Forged Scroll — A tax ledger is discovered to be a forgery. The party is blamed. The real forger is a Censorate clerk.
4	Quiet Chancellor’s Interest — The Chancellor requests a private audience. Refusal is treason. Attendance incurs a favor.
5	Lethai-thora Silence-Token — A hidden archivist offers a token in exchange for a secret. The secret will be witnessed by the dead.
6	Well of Erased Names — A character sees their own name floating in the well. The Hollow is watching. Gain the <i>Marked</i> condition.

Hidden Archive Discoveries (d8)

When the party explores the Lethai-thora Hidden Archive or the Ninth Ledger's Vault, roll to determine what forgotten secret they uncover.

d8	Discovery
1	A scroll that proves the current emperor's claim is false.
2	A map of the Ninth Ledger's vault, sealed with a finger bone key.
3	A forgotten ancestor tablet still warm to the touch.
4	The true name of a Veiled Sister, written in disappearing ink.
5	A Lethai-thora memory-thread containing the last breath of a dead emperor.
6	The original Mandate of Heaven, showing the ninth clause was added later.
7	A canal mother's key that opens any sluice gate — and a ghost that wants it back.
8	A blank scroll that writes itself when no one is watching. It is writing your obituary.

Water Rights Disputes (d6)

When a conflict arises over canal access or irrigation, roll to determine the nature of the dispute.

d6	Dispute
1	A Canal Mother accuses a rival of diverting water after dark. The evidence is a single wet footprint.
2	The Dragon King is offended. A barge carrying a forbidden ancestor tablet has contaminated the lock.
3	A salt merchant claims the right to dam a tributary for his pans. The farmers downstream are sharpening sickles.
4	The water level dropped overnight. A ghostly Canal Mother walks the lock, demanding to know who stole her key.
5	Two examination candidates accuse each other of bribing the lockmaster. The lockmaster has vanished.
6	The Ninth Lock has frozen in summer. The Hollow is breathing through the ice. No one will go near it.

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Timer (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (passes, seals, tokens) that change position rather than call for a roll.

- If any A appears, echo **ink-omens**—scrolls that rustle in still air, a lamp that burns green, a forgotten name whispered from a shelf, a ghost that asks for a pen.

Additional Features (Celestial Bureaucracy)

- **The Mandate Timer [8] (Shared Campaign Timer):** Tracks the stability of the dynasty. The party inherits 2 ticks at the start of any adventure set in Sihai (the inherited burden). The timer ticks when the emperor’s health fails, when a succession dispute arises, when a major corruption scandal is exposed, or when the party breaks an oath witnessed by an ancestor. When the timer reaches 4: the Censorate becomes more aggressive (all audits start at Desperate Position). When it reaches 8: the Mandate fails — the Hollow claims the throne, civil war erupts, and the party must choose a side or flee. Resetting the timer requires an **Ancestor Rite** at the Imperial Ancestral Temple (downtime, costs 1 Supply and a truthful confession) or a public execution of a corrupt official (costs 1 Boon and may create enemies).
- **The Two Ledgers (Ancestral Names Mechanic):** Every character has two “names”: their **Mortal Name** (what the Censorate knows) and their **Ancestral Name** (recorded in the Celestial Ledger, kept by the Lethai-thora). The Ancestral Name cannot be erased by mortal means. Discovering a character’s Ancestral Name requires a **Research Timer (size 6)** in the Lethai-thora archives. Once known, the player may invoke the Ancestral Name once per session to gain +2 dice on any roll related to that ancestor’s domain (e.g., a farmer’s ancestor aids harvest, a soldier’s ancestor aids battle). However, invoking the Ancestral Name creates an **Ancestral Weight (size 4 timer)**. When it fills, the ancestor demands a service — usually something the ancestor failed to do in life (e.g., “Apologize to my widow” or “Find my stolen seal”). Refusing the demand marks 1 Corruption and adds 2 ticks to the Mandate Timer .
- **Censorate Audit (Social Combat Mechanic):** The Censorate can audit any character at any time. An audit is a social combat with three phases:
 1. **Pleadings** (Presence + Sway vs. Censor’s Lore). Success grants +1 die to the next phase.
 2. **Evidence** (Wits + Investigation vs. DV 4). Success reveals a hidden burden or a forged document; failure gives the Censor a piece of evidence against you.
 3. **Judgment** (Resolve + Lore vs. DV 5). Success: the character is cleared. Failure: the Censorate erases a name — the character loses one Bond (that person no longer remembers them) or one Asset (it is seized), and the Mandate Timer ticks +1.

Players can avoid an audit by: **Bribing the Censor** (costs 1 Honey Jar or 1 Boon), **Presenting a forged document** (requires a Forgery Timer , size 4), or **Calling a ghost witness** (requires a Spirit + Lore test, DV 4; the ghost cannot lie, but it will ask for a favor in return – usually a promise that creates a new Ancestral Weight).
- **Examination Hell (Dungeon Mechanic):** The Forbidden Garden contains a subterranean examination hall where the ghosts of failed candidates still write their answers. The party can enter to find a lost Ancestral Name – but the hall is alive.
 - The hall has a **Stress Timer (size 8)**. Each failed roll, each lie spoken, each broken taboo ticks the timer.
 - At 4: The hall begins to change. Doors lead to different corridors. Navigation becomes Desperate.
 - At 8: The **Examiner Ghost** appears — a skeleton in scholar’s robes. It asks one question. The party must answer in verse. If the verse is good, the ghost grants a boon (reveals one Ancestral Name). If poor, the ghost erases one of the party’s names — that character is forgotten by the

living for 1d4 days (lose all Bonds temporarily, cannot be recognized). The Stress Timer resets after the encounter.

- **Paper Soldiers and Hungry Ghosts (Minion Types):**
 - **Paper Soldiers (Tier I, Cap 2):** Origami constructs animated by Censorate magic. They have Harm 2, Body 2, Melee 1. They are Vulnerable to fire (double Harm) and to a successful Lore test (reveals their true name, causing them to crumple).
 - **Hungry Ghosts (Tier II, Cap 3):** Spirits of those whose names were erased. They have Harm 3, Spirit 3, and the ability **Memory Drain** (touch, target forgets a minor detail — a face, a password, a skill point for one scene). They cannot cross a line of salt or a properly witnessed oath-circle.
- **Water Rights as Ancestral Currency:** In the canal system, water rights are traded like silver, but they are also offerings to the Dragon Kings of the Four Seas. A Canal Mother’s key is worth more than a chest of coins — it can also summon a rain spirit (once per season, calm a storm or flood a district). Forging a water right angers the Dragon King; the forger’s wells run dry for nine years (all Survival tests to find water suffer –2 dice).
- **Lethai-thora Archivists of the First Seal:** The Lethai-thora are not merely librarians — they are the keepers of the original Mandate, written on tortoise shells and dragon bones. They do not serve the emperor; they serve the record that predates the empire. A Lethai-thora keeper can declare any document void by writing “void” in water over it. The water must be from the Well of Erased Names. Doing so costs 1 Obligation to the Lethai-thora and ticks the Mandate Timer +1 (the Censorate will investigate).
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Jade Censor** — The Witness. *A magistrate who never blinks, who writes every truth in a ledger of jade.*
 - **The Dragon Salt** — Maelstraeus. *The price of a monopoly; the hidden cost of a nation’s thirst.*
 - **The Ninth Ancestor** — Khemesh. *The ghost of the first emperor, who still reviews petitions.*
 - **The Brush That Walks** — The Traveler. *A calligraphy brush that guides lost officials through the underworld.*
 - **The Kitchen’s Ear** — The Sealed Gate. *The god who reports every secret to the Celestial Bureaucracy.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Ninth Ledger and the Kalrantha Amulet (Dhahara):** The ninth ledger is said to contain the name of the prince who stole the amulet. The Veiled Sisters want to erase it. The Breath-less want to find it. The Lethai-thora have hidden it in a scroll that unrolls forever.
- **Silence-Tokens and the Covenant (Mykkiel):** The Covenant recognizes Lethai-thora silence-tokens as valid requests for closed hearings. A silence token can pause any court proceeding for the duration of a single breath. The token is a strip of silk from a burial shroud.
- **Canal Mothers and the Fhara (Way of Silk):** Fhara well-judges and Sihai canal mothers use similar water-measuring systems. A canal mother’s key can be used to negotiate a well contract — but the key must be dipped in the well first. The water will remember.
- **The Mandate and the Hollow (Eastern Realms):** The Hollow is the silence at the heart of the Mandate. Aelaerem hedge-keepers say that when a dynasty falls, the Hollow eats the ninth

name. The name is always the emperor’s secret childhood name.

Sihai Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Canal:** Crumble a crust into the water. Ignore the first *Forged Scroll* penalty. [SUPERSTITION]
- **Knot the Scroll:** Tie a single knot in a silk cord. Cancel *Censorate Audit* or take −1 die on your next forgery detection roll (your choice). [SUPERSTITION]
- **Name to the Well:** Whisper a dead censor’s name into the Well of Erased Names. Gain +1 Effect when negotiating with the Censorate this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Hollow. [SUPERSTITION]

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **Censorate clerks or ancestor ghosts**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **canal patrols or hungry ghosts**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or the Kitchen God**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable water level**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource timer**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Local censor or canal mother** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **fog or a ghost procession**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **paper soldier (origami construct) or a hungry ghost** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **Censorate guards, ancestor spirits, or paper soldiers** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes—**ancestor summoned/ledger stolen/mandate questioned**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front timer by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Quiet Chancellor, Salt Commissioner, or First Censor’s Ghost** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically—**canal floods/archive burns/mandate falls**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice—**omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.

- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Sihai (Celestial Bureaucracy):** A ghost clerk appears with a writ, a paper seal floats down from nowhere, the Emperor's Dreamer whispers a warning.
- **Sihai (Ancestor Law):** A family shrine glows, an ancestor's portrait weeps ink, a forgotten burden is recalled in a dream.
- **Sihai (Examination Hell):** A failed candidate's ghost asks for a pen, a test paper bleeds, the proctor's bell rings nine times.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Navigation):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Paper Trail*.
- **Cut the Seal (Presence + Lore):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a stamped pass is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Audit (Resolve + Spirit):** On a hit in *Censorate Audit*, you pick who testifies; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Brush & Mandate)

- **The Forgotten Emperor (Ghost of the Ninth Seal)** — *Phases:* Names Erased → Ledger Stolen → Mandate Reclaimed. *Cracks:* present a true ancestor tablet, expose a forged lineage, survive a night in the Well of Erased Names.
- **The Brush That Writes Itself (Living Ink)** — *Phases:* Paper Soldiers → Scroll Prison → Ink Flood. *Cracks:* a Lethai-thora silence-token, a confession written in water, the First Censor's Brush.

Patronage & Power

In Sihai, power flows through ink, salt, and the weight of the Mandate. The Emperor rules, but the Censorate audits, the Salt Monopoly finances, the Lethai-thora remember, and the ancestors watch. A well-written couplet can appease a ghost; a forged seal can start a war. The Celestial Bureaucracy is always hiring.

For the GM: Power in Sihai is measured in examination scores, salt licenses, and the thickness of a family's archive. Patronage often takes the form of stamped passes, ledger copies, or silence-tokens — each tied to a specific office, canal, or burden. To emphasize the mythological flavor:

- Use the **Mandate Timer** as a visible campaign front. The party's actions can tick or reset it. Ancestor rites are the only safe way to reduce it.
- Enforce **Censorate Audits** as a recurring threat — players must maintain clean papers or face erasure. Ghost witnesses can be summoned by either side.
- Let **water rights** be a form of currency that can be stolen, forged, or contested — but angering the Dragon King has consequences.
- Introduce **paper soldiers** (origami constructs) as low-tier enemies and **hungry ghosts** as mid-tier threats. The Censorate employs both.

In Sihai, the brush forgets nothing — and the Hollow remembers every erased name.

Chapter 7

Nihori

The Isles of the Dawn Spirit.

I ruled the waves before the Hollow learned to walk. My empire sank because I spoke a name I should not have. Do not speak my name. Do not ask what it was. The sea remembers. That is enough.

I am a Wanderer. I carry a broken sword and a grudge. The sword was my father's. The grudge is mine. The man who killed him died nine years ago. I still walk the isles, looking for his ghost. The ghost is looking for me too.

Nihori is a chain of volcanic islands, shrouded in mist and lashed by storms. Here, the old empire sank beneath the waves, and the Lethai-al guard the drowned kingdom's memory. The people are wanderers, duelists, and shrine maidens. They worship the storm spirits and fear the ninth wave. The Hollow breathes in the salt foam; the Oath-Keepers ride the tide. But here's the secret the Shogun doesn't want you to know: the old empire did not sink. It was pulled under. And whatever pulled it is still down there, waiting for the ninth wave to break the right way.

The Shogun sits in a half-ruined castle, his authority challenged by three rival daimyo who sharpen their blades and their treaties. Oni cults whisper in the ash wastes, offering forgotten bargains. The Storm Emperor's ghost does not rule—but his silence haunts every island. The ninth taboo is absolute: never speak the name of the drowned capital. The sea will hear you, and it will ask why you called. And when the sea asks a question, it expects an answer—in blood, in memory, or in a name you did not mean to give.

Never speak the name of the drowned capital. The sea will hear you, and it will ask why you called.

— *The Storm Emperor's Ghost, who appears as a column of steam over the water*

What do people eat for breakfast? *Grilled fish and pickled vegetables—the fish is caught in the caldera lakes, the vegetables are fermented in clay pots buried in volcanic ash. The ash is warm. The warmth is the mountain's breath. The mountain is sleeping. The mountain dreams of the drowned empire.*

What does a child learn before they can walk? *To read the tide. Nihori children are taught the eight wave-heights: Calm, Ripple, Swell, Storm, Tsunami, and the ninth—the wave that has no height because it is the sea itself rising. The ninth wave is the drowning. The drowning is the empire's memory.*

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? *Their sword. Nihori warriors carry their ancestors' blades, passed down for generations. A stranger whose sword is rusted has forgotten their lineage. A stranger whose sword is sharp has remembered. A stranger with no sword is a coward. Cowards are not fed.*

What is the most common crime? *Dueling—but dueling is not a crime, it is a conversation. The dueling codes are written in verse. The verses are interpreted by the Shogun's court. The interpretations are contradictory. The contradictions are settled by dueling. The circle is beautiful.*

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? *The drowned capital is not underwater. It is beneath—beneath the caldera, beneath the bedrock, beneath the world. The sea is a lid. The lid is cracked. Something is leaking through. The leaks are the oni. The oni are the empire's regrets.*

Where do people go when they die? *To the sea cliffs. The dead are placed in caves overlooking the water. The waves sing to them. The songs are the empire's lullabies. The dead listen. The dead do not sleep.*

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? *You offer a duel—a matched contest with the wronged party's choice of weapon. If you lose, you are forgiven. If you win, you are not. If you refuse, you are exiled. Exile is the open sea. The sea is patient. The sea will wait.*

What is the most important festival? *The Calling of the Tides (spring). The shrine maidens walk into the water, singing the names of the drowned. The waves answer. The waves speak the names of the living who will die in the coming year. The names are never forgotten. The names are never repeated.*

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? *The Shogun is a ghost. He died in the last oni war, but his body was never found. The daimyo rule in his name because they are afraid of what will happen if they admit he is gone. The oni know. The oni are waiting for the admission. The admission will be the war.*

b & Atmosphere

Red threads tied to every gate, every bridge, every well. The smell of burnt rice and old salt. The way the Aelaerem never whistle after dusk—the Hollow thinks you are calling it. And the way they never, ever count to nine.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never count the steps between your door and the crossroads. The Hollow counts with you. If you reach nine, it will be waiting at the ninth step. It will ask, "Where are you going?" Do not answer.

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Regional Mood: The Weight of the Unspoken

Power here is measured in red threads tied, offerings left, and the gaps between words. The Aelaerem have no leaders, no courts, no written laws. Each hedge-keeper knows her own stretch of boundary. She knows where the Hollow walks, when it is restless, and what gesture will turn it aside. Her authority is not given by any king — it is earned by surviving the uncanny. The Aelaerem are not

feared or respected; they are tolerated, because without them the Hollow would seep into every threshold. They are the neighbors of the thing that lives between the notes of a song.

Starting Location

A crossroads at dusk, where a red thread is tied around a wooden post. An old Aelaerem woman is pouring a cup of sake onto the ground. She looks up: “The Hollow walked last night. I left salt. It took the salt. It left a single red thread tied around my wrist. It moved. Sleep with that knot, and it will know where you are. Do you want to know where it went? It went toward your camp.”

The Almanac of Ordinary Days (Eastern Aelaerem)

What do people eat for breakfast? *Rice porridge with pickled vegetables—the rice is from the paddies, the vegetables are salted in clay pots buried at the boundary. The salt is blessed by the hedge-keeper. The vegetables are always a little bitter. The bitterness is a reminder.*

What does a child learn before they can walk? *To tie the eight boundary knots. The ninth knot is never tied—it is left loose for the Hollow to find. If a child ties the ninth knot, the Hollow will visit that night and ask for a name. The child’s name.*

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? *Their shadow. A stranger whose shadow is too short has been touched by the Hollow. A stranger whose shadow moves independently is already lost. A stranger with no shadow is the Hollow itself, wearing a borrowed face. Do not invite them in.*

What is the most common crime? *Thread-theft—stealing a red thread from a boundary marker. The thread is not valuable, but cutting it breaks a promise. The Hollow becomes restless. The thief is marked: their shadow will shrink one inch each night until they return the thread.*

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? *The Hollow is not a single thing. It is a place—the space between heartbeats, the pause before a sneeze, the silence after a bell. The Aelaerem do not guard against a monster. They guard against the gaps.*

Where do people go when they die? *To the salt. The dead are cremated, and their ashes are mixed with salt and scattered along the boundary. The salt draws the Hollow’s attention away from the living. The dead become the new boundary. They do not rest. They watch.*

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? *You leave a cup of sake and a lock of hair at the place where the wrong was done. The Hollow will witness. If the sake is gone by dawn and the hair is untouched, you are forgiven. If the hair is gone, the Hollow has taken your apology as a promise. You are now bound. Do not break that promise.*

What is the most important festival? *The Retting of the Threads (spring). All red threads on the boundary are taken down, washed in salt water, and re-tied. The village is silent for one night—no bells, no songs, no whispers. The Hollow listens. The Hollow remembers. If a thread is tied wrong, the Hollow will correct it. The correction is always a death.*

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? *The first red thread was not tied by an Aelaerem. It was tied by the Hollow itself, before it forgot what it was. The thread is still there, at the First Boundary. If it is untied, the Hollow will remember its true name. Then it will stop being hungry. It will become something else. No one knows what.*

b & Atmosphere

The sound of copper bells — not ringing in sequence, but chiming in overlapping waves. The way every bridge has a missing ninth plank. The smell of pickled plums and salt.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never count to nine aloud near a shrine. The spirits count with you. When you reach nine, they will ask: “What comes after nine?” The answer is always the Hollow.

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Regional Mood: The Weight of the Count

Power here is measured in bells rung, tides predicted, and the precision of a threshold. The Aelinnel have no kings or councils; their authority rests on the bell-wardens who maintain the shrines and the tide-counters who read the waves. A village that loses its bell-warden is a village that the tide-spirits will flood. A bridge without its ninth plank missing is a bridge that the Hollow will cross. The Aelinnel do not worship the spirits; they transact with them. An offering is not a prayer — it is a payment. A bell is not a musical instrument — it is a contract.

Starting Location

A floating shrine on the Inland Sea, where copper bells hang from every corner. A Bell-Warden rings a bell eight times, then stops: “The tide-spirit is restless. It wants a ninth bell. I will not give it. You — count the waves. Tell me how many break before the sun sets. If you miscount, the spirit will ask you for a story. Do not miscount.”

The Almanac of Ordinary Days (Aelinnel)

What do people eat for breakfast? *Rice porridge with pickled plums — the plums are fermented in salt brine and stored in copper-lidded barrels. The brine is never poured out; it is passed down through generations. The oldest batch is said to be nine generations old. No one has tasted it.*

What does a child learn before they can walk? *To count the eight safe numbers. Children are taught to count pebbles, footsteps, and bell-rings — but always to stop at eight. The ninth is never spoken. A child who says “nine” aloud is sent to sit by the missing plank of the bridge until they forget they ever said it.*

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? *Their fingers. Aelinnel tide-counters often have only eight fingers — the ninth was a miscount they paid for. A stranger with nine fingers has never made a mistake. A stranger with seven has paid a heavy debt. A stranger with no fingers is either a spirit or someone who counted to nine and lost everything.*

What is the most common crime? *Bell-theft — but not for the copper. A stolen bell can be rung at the wrong time, creating a miscount. The thief is not punished by law; they are given to the tide-spirit whose count was broken. The spirit decides the price.*

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? *The First Bell was not cast by an Aelinnel. It was found — already ringing, already counting. No one knows who made it. No one knows why it rang. The shards are scattered across the Inland Sea. When the ninth shard is found, the First Bell will ring again. The Hollow will hear it.*

Where do people go when they die? *To the bell-line. The dead are not buried. Their ashes are mixed with copper dust and cast into new bells. The bells are hung on the bell-lines. When the tide-spirits ring them, the dead speak. Mostly they say: “Count carefully.”*

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? *You offer a count — a public recitation of the wrong, spoken in eights. “I took the offering. I broke the bell. I counted to nine.” Then you wait. If a spirit rings a bell eight times, you are forgiven. If it rings nine times, you are cursed. If no bell rings, the Hollow will visit you at midnight.*

What is the most important festival? *The Retuning of the Bells (autumn). Every bell on the Inland Sea is struck once, in sequence, from the highest tide to the lowest. The sound travels for miles. The spirits listen. If a bell is out of tune, the spirits will correct it by morning. The correction is always a death — but the bell will ring true for another year.*

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? *The ninth bell was never meant to be cast. It was a mistake — a foundry worker poured one bell too many. They tried to hide it, but it rang*

once on its own. The tone was the Hollow's name. The bell still exists. It is buried under a shrine on a small island. No one knows which island. The map was miscounted.

b & Atmosphere

The smell of salt and incense. The way the Lethai-al never sit with their backs to the sea. The constant, low murmur of waves being predicted — not by instruments, but by the tilt of a head, the twitch of a finger. The worn wooden plaques hung from their belts, each carved with a dead ancestor's name.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never walk under a torii gate without making an offering. The gate is a threshold. The road on the other side is not the same road you left.

!

Regional Mood: The Processional Road

Power here is measured in shrines visited, storms survived, and the number of dead ancestors carried as tide-charms. The Lethai-al have no king, no courts, no written law. Their authority is personal and processional: a Procession Elder's word is law because she has walked the circuit more times than anyone else. Their guilds are not guilds — they are processional bands, each with its own rhythm, its own counting song, its own patron shrine. A band that walks too fast offends the spirits; one that walks too slow loses the tide. The Lethai-al do not believe in ownership of land; they believe in passage rights, storm oaths, and the memory of the drowned. Every crossroads is a court. Every storm is a messenger. Every sunrise is a departure.

Starting Location

A procession trail winding along the sea cliffs, marked by weathered torii gates and small stone shrines. A group of Lethai-al walk in single file, chanting a counting song. One carries a palanquin with a covered object — a tide-charm shrine. The leader stops: “You stand on the processional road. The drowned are watching from the waves. Do you walk with us? If so, you must carry nothing. The road provides. The road takes away.”

The Almanac of Ordinary Days (Lethai-al)

What do people eat for breakfast? *Dried fish and rice balls — the fish is smoked over driftwood fires, the rice is pressed into shapes that fit in a pouch. The food is always cold. The Lethai-al do not stop to cook. The road does not wait.*

What does a child learn before they can walk? *To count the nine waves. Children are taught to watch the sea and count: one, two, three, four, five, six, seven, eight — then stop. The ninth wave is the spirit's wave. It counts you. If you count it, you owe it.*

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? *Their feet. A Lethai-al who has walked the circuit for many years has calloused soles cracked like dry earth. A stranger with soft feet has not walked far. A stranger with no feet is a ghost who lost the road.*

What is the most common crime? *Charm-theft — stealing a tide-charm from a sleeping traveler. The thief gains the dead ancestor's favor for one night. The ancestor wakes. The ancestor is angry. The punishment is to carry the victim's burden for the rest of the circuit.*

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? *The drowned kingdom did not sink by accident. The forbidden name was spoken by a Lethai-al — a woman who lost her child to the sea. She wanted the sea to remember. It remembered too well. Her name is not spoken. Her tide-charm hangs in the Sunken Gate, still wet.*

Where do people go when they die? *Into the tide-charms. The dead are not buried. Their names are carved onto shells and placed in oiled leather pouches. The living carry them. The dead walk with the living. When the pouch is lost, the dead become the Hollow.*

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? *You walk a crossroads circuit — nine times around a crossroads shrine, counting your steps in eights. On the ninth circuit, you must speak the wrong aloud. If the wind carries your voice away, you are forgiven. If the wind throws it back, you are not. If the wind is silent, the Hollow is listening.*

What is the most important festival? *The Procession of the Ninth Wave (autumn). All Lethai-al bands walk to the shore at low tide. When the ninth wave crashes, they wade into the foam and whisper the names of those who drowned that year. The sea answers with a single wave. The wave is always the same height. The height is the number of names.*

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? *The Ninth Wave Herald is not a child. She is the first drowned — the woman who spoke the forbidden name. She did not die. She became the ninth wave. She returns every year to point at the horizon. She is pointing at the day the sea will rise again. No one knows which day.*

b & Atmosphere

The smell of river water and oiled silk. The way every Lethai-ar carries a small oil lamp, even at noon. The constant murmur of contracts being witnessed — a merchant's promise, a captain's oath, a lover's vow.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never pour the ninth cup of tea or sake in a Lethai-ar's presence. The ninth cup is for the witness. Pour it, and you have invited the river to judge you. The river is not merciful.

!

Regional Mood: The Weight of the Witness Cord

Power here is measured in lanterns kept lit, cords tied, and the number of oaths witnessed. The Lethai-ar have no army, no treasury, no territory. They have the river, and the river remembers everything. Every contract in Ayokha requires a Lethai-ar witness to be legally binding. The God-King's astrologers may set the calendar, but the Lethai-ar hold the ledger. Their neutrality is absolute: they will witness a vow between enemies as readily as between allies. The price of a witness cord is not silver — it is a promise to keep the river clean, to light a lamp at dusk, to speak no word that cannot be unsaid.

Starting Location

A monsoon wharf on the great river, where silk barges are being loaded. A Vigil in gray robes holds a lantern of green flame: "The merchant and the captain have made a vow. The captain says the silk is eight bales. The merchant says it is nine. The witness cord is tied. It will tighten around the liar's wrist. I do not need to know who is lying. The cord will tell me. But you — you are not bound. Watch. Learn. And do not pour the ninth cup."

The Almanac of Ordinary Days (Lethai-ar of Ayokha)

What do people eat for breakfast? *Rice porridge with river fish — the fish are caught in the sacred currents, and the bones are returned to the water as an offering. The porridge is salted with evaporated river brine. It tastes of memory.*

What does a child learn before they can walk? *To tie the eight witness knots. Each knot represents a clause of a fair contract. The ninth knot is never tied — it is left for the river to judge. A child who*

ties the ninth knot is taken to the step-pyramid and made to watch the green flame until they can recite every oath their family has ever sworn.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? *Their lamp. A Lethai-ar's lamp is a public record of their witness. A stranger whose lamp burns green has kept every oath. A stranger whose lamp flickers has witnessed a broken vow. A stranger whose lamp is dark has been cut from the Vigil. Do not speak to them. The river may be listening.*

What is the most common crime? *Cord-forging — creating a false witness cord that mimics the dye of a respected Vigil. The forger is not executed. Their hands are bound with a cord that tightens each time they speak. If they never lie, the cord will eventually loosen. If they lie once, it will cut.*

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? *The First Cord was not woven by a Lethai-ar. It was found — already knotted, already witnessing — floating down the river on a broken barge. No one knows who tied it. No one knows what oath it witnessed. The cord is kept in a lead-lined box at the bottom of the Well of Broken Oaths. The box is warm. The cord is still waiting.*

Where do people go when they die? *To the green flame. The dead are cremated, and their ashes are mixed with lamp oil. The oil is poured into the Vigil lanterns. The dead become the light. The light witnesses. The light does not lie.*

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? *You offer a new cord — woven from your own hair, dyed with your own blood. The cord is tied between you and the wronged party. If the cord tightens, you are not forgiven. If it loosens, you are. If it breaks, the river will decide your fate. The river is patient.*

What is the most important festival? *The Reckoning of the Cords (spring). All witness cords that have been cut or broken are taken from the Well of Broken Oaths and burned in a barge on the river. The smoke rises. The river spirits watch. If a cord does not burn, the oath it witnessed is still unpaid. The debtor has one more year. If the same cord fails to burn twice, the Hollow comes.*

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? *The God-King's own witness cord is a forgery. He swore a vow to protect the Lethai-ar nine years ago. His cord was cut the next day. The Vigil knows. They have not told anyone because the cord that cut his was their own. The ninth cord that Lady Suyin cut was the king's. She has been waiting for him to break his oath ever since. He will. They always do.*

b & Atmosphere

The smell of old parchment and incense. The way scrolls are stacked with their spines facing the wall — so the words cannot see who reads them. The silence when a secret is spoken; even the insects stop chirping.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never touch a scroll without announcing your lineage. Even a false lineage is better than silence. The scrolls remember who opened them, and they will whisper your name to the Hollow.

Part VII

The Spaces Between

“The Ways Between do not measure miles. They measure choices. A wrong turn might lead to yesterday. A right turn might lead to a version of yourself who made a different decision – and is still alive to regret it. The mist does not hide landmarks. It hides destinations.” — Dusana of the Raven Road, at a crossroads that did not exist on any map

Chapter 8

Ubral

The Stone Between Spears.

The stone here remembers every oath sworn upon it and every blood spilled in its shadow. To lead is to understand that the land itself is the true sovereign, and we are merely its stewards.

I am a Hearth-Aunt. Hospitality's a sacred thing in these hills—break bread at my table and you're family till the sun sets twice. But cross that trust and the very stones will remember your name.

Ubral is a land of upland mists, stone cairns, and clan oaths held tighter than iron. Caught between the Aelerian mountains and the lowland courts of Viterra, its hills are scarred by old raids and crowned by watch-fires that speak faster than any rider. Here, law is written not in charters but in cattle, wergild, and songs; a guest's word can buy more than a sword, but one broken vow can spark a feud lasting generations. But here's the secret the Lady of Tor doesn't want you to know: the cairns are not just markers. They are witnesses. Every stone in every cairn has a name. If you touch the right stone, you can hear the dead voting on the disputes of the living. The dead have long memories. They vote with the wind.

Viterra has tried to conquer Ubral a dozen times; each attempt ended with supply lines cut by reivers, passes sealed by Aeler outcast engineers, and lowland knights lost in mist. The Utaran Imperium itself broke its leg on these hills and limped away. Now the clans watch the lowlands with patient eyes, and the exiled Aeler of Khaz-Vurim weigh every traveler's honesty on iron scales. A guest here is kin—until they prove otherwise. And kin here will die for you—or kill you over a stolen cow.

Never refuse a cup from a hearth-aunt. Hospitality is a contract sealed in

salt and bread. Refusal is an insult that blood must answer.

— *Hearth-Aunt Brigid, who has never drawn a blade and has never needed to*

What do people eat for breakfast? Oatcakes and skyr—the oats are grown in highland clearings, the skyr is cultured in stone crocks buried in the peat. The peat is ancient. The peat remembers the old kings. The old kings are buried beneath it.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To count cattle. Ubral children are taught the eight breeds of the hills: Black, Red, White, Brindled, Dun, Gray, Spotted, and the ninth—the breed that has no color because it belongs to the cairn-folk. The cairn-folk are the dead. The dead do not pay taxes.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their guest-token. Every Ubral traveler carries a token—a stone, a bone, a braid of hair—given by their last host. A stranger whose token is warm has been recently welcomed. A stranger whose token is cold has been traveling long. A stranger with no token is a spy. Spies are given a token—a rope. The rope is for their neck.

What is the most common crime? Cattle raiding—but raiding is not a crime, it is a sport. The cattle are the wealth. The wealth is the clan's. A stolen cow is a stolen child. The child must be returned. The return is a negotiation. The negotiation is a feud. The feud is a song.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Lady of Tor is not the ruler. The cairns rule. The cairns vote at each full moon. Their votes are carried by the wind. The wind speaks to the hearth-aunts. The hearth-aunts speak to the clan. The clan obeys. The Lady is the voice. The cairns are the vote.

Where do people go when they die? To the cairns. The dead are not buried. Their bones are added to the cairns. The cairns grow taller each year. The tallest cairn is the oldest. The oldest cairn has no name. The oldest cairn remembers the first clan.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a wergild—a payment in cattle, calculated by the wronged party's estimate of their loss. The cattle are driven to the cairn. The cairn is the court. If the cattle graze peacefully, you are forgiven. If they scatter, you are not. If they refuse to enter the cairn's shadow, your debt is blood.

What is the most important festival? The Gathering of the Clans (autumn). The clans meet at the Great Cairn. The cattle are counted. The songs are sung. The feuds are settled. The dead are named. The wind carries the names to the hills. The hills remember.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Great Cairn is not a cairn. It is a prison—the tomb of a Viterran king who tried to conquer Ubral and failed. He was buried alive, with his crown and his sword. His ghost votes with the cairns. He votes for war. The cairns have not yet agreed.

The Ninth and the Hollow

What the Hollow Is

The Hollow is not a monster, a god, or a place. It is the **unpaid interest** of every promise broken, every name erased, every debt that was never settled. It exists in the **gaps** between counted things: the ninth step that is never there, the ninth cup that is never poured, the ninth night that is never stayed. The Hollow does not hate. It does not forgive. It *remembers*.

The Ninth Taboo Across Regions

The following table lists how the ninth taboo manifests in each realm. Use it to introduce consistent supernatural dread without over-explaining.

Region	Ninth Taboo / Manifestation
Kahfagia	The ninth lantern code – a signal never used; it means "kill the witnesses."
Ecktoria	The ninth citation of precedent voids all previous; the Hollow laughs from the marble walls.
Acasia	The ninth bridge toll is collected by a child with no name; the Curse remembers.
Vhasia	The ninth citation in court voids the case; the dead king laughs, and the Hollow listens.
Viterra	The ninth citation voids all previous; the Hollow's accountant appears at midnight.
Thepyrgos	The ninth bell rings without a clapper; the Unfinished Stair appears.
Aeler	The ninth breath taken in a mine summons the pressure that thinks.
Mistlands	The ninth bell on the line opens a gate; wraiths step through.
Ykrul	The ninth cup poured at a feast is for the ancestors; the Hollow drinks if they refuse.
Vilikari	The ninth witness called to a mallus court is always a ghost; the living forget themselves.
Black Banners	The ninth tent in a row collapses before dawn; the ground beneath is always damp.
Linns	The ninth horn blown at a feast summons the Hollow; a gray figure waits at the high table.
Sihai	The ninth citation in the Celestial Ledger is unwritten; speaking it erases the speaker.
Nihori	The ninth wave never breaks; it is the sea's breath, waiting.
Ayokha	The ninth cup poured invites the river to judge; the water rises.

Dhahara (Satrapies)	The ninth breath taken in a mine is the mountain's; the Hollow takes a memory.
Dhahara (Brass Coast)	The ninth lamp on every lighthouse is never lit; it is reserved for the collector.
Fhara	The ninth cup poured at a well-court is for the Hollow; the well-spirit falls silent.
Sidhi (Galanina)	The ninth flash of the lighthouse lamp is never used; it signals the collector's arrival.
Pereshi	The ninth verse of the epic is missing; the Hollow speaks it only to the dead.
Kuvani	The ninth horse in a remount string has no name; it carries the Hollow's rider.
Tulkani	The ninth night in a circle summons the Hollow; it asks for a story it has never heard.
Oshiira	The ninth page of the Grain Ledger is sealed with black wax; it names the debtors the Hollow claims.
Ashaan	The ninth name erased from the ledger is never written; it belongs to the Hollow.
Ngomebe	The ninth roller beneath a walking city is never greased; the Hollow walks beside it.
Taharka	The ninth wind has no name; it is the mountain's breath, and the Hollow rides it.
Sekogo	The ninth nail in a nkisi is always loose; the Hollow's spirit whispers through it.
Lethai-ar (Crimson Valley)	The ninth strand of a silk bridge is invisible; the Hollow walks it.
Theona	The ninth cup is never poured; the Green Host rides for those who pour it.
Zakov	The ninth ship to enter the harbour in a tide is claimed by the reef; the Hollow's mouth.
Aelinnel (Aevrossa)	The ninth word spoken in a bargain is legally binding; the Hollow is the witness.
Aelaerem (Hollow's Neighbors)	The ninth knot is never tied; the Hollow unties one each year.
Valewood	The ninth leaf to fall from a tree points to a hidden threshold; the Hollow waits inside.
Ways Between (Obishaal)	The ninth step on any path lands on a threshold you did not see; the Hollow asks a question.
Dungeons (Living Infrastructure)	The ninth door you open leads to a place not on your map; the Hollow offers a shortcut.

Manifestations of the Hollow – GM Toolkit

Use these as recurring adversaries or atmospheric pressure. None are “boss fights” in the traditional sense; they are **creditors** who demand payment in stories, memories, or names.

- **Oath-Keeper:** A tall figure in gray with too many fingers. It appears when a promise is broken or a ninth taboo is violated. It asks one question. The answer must be a truth, a story, or a name. If you cannot pay, it takes a memory – and the Hollow’s attention follows you.
- **Still Voice:** Heard at dried wells, abandoned cairns, or sealed mines. It asks: “Why did you stop?” or “What did you forget?” Answering costs a breath; silence costs a shadow.
- **Prince’s Shadow (Pereshi):** A silhouette without a face, seen in mirrors and still water. It demands a name – any name. Give it a living person’s name, and that person dreams of the Hollow. Give it your own, and you lose your shadow.
- **The Ninth Bell (Mistlands / Thepyrgos):** A bell that rings without a clapper. Those who hear it must test Resolve (DV 4) or lose 1 Fatigue. If they hear it nine times, the Hollow claims a memory.
- **The Counting Circle (Tulkani):** A wagon circle on the ninth night. The Hollow appears at the edge and asks for a story it has never heard. The GM may demand a player tell a brief in-character story; if it satisfies the table, the Hollow retreats. If not, it takes a knot – and a piece of Ikasha’s dream.

Pacing the Hollow – Advice for GMs

- **Start subtle.** The first sign of the Hollow should be a missed echo, a candle that gutters, a door that opens when no one is there.
- **Use timers.** The Hollow’s attention is best tracked with a **Hollow Attention [6]** timer that ticks when players break a taboo or ignore an omen. When it fills, a manifestation appears.
- **Do not overuse.** The Hollow is most effective when it appears once every 2–3 sessions. Let players forget it – then remind them.
- **Never fully explain it.** The Hollow’s origin (the unpaid interest of the Omens’ scouring) is endgame lore. In regular play, it is simply *the space between counted things*.

For the GM: The Spider, the Snake, the Raven – What to Reveal and When

The three Omens (Inaea, Isoka, Ikasha) are not gods. They are forces that appear in whispers, dreams, and the spaces between counted things. Do not introduce them directly. Instead, let players encounter their echoes: a rope that never frays (Inaea), a judgment that cuts clean (Isoka), a dream that feels too real (Ikasha). By the time players learn the names, they should have already felt their presence for many sessions.

The full truth of the Omens – the Clockwork Demon, the scouring, Ikasha’s imprisonment – is **endgame content**. Use the fragments in this book as breadcrumbs. If players ask a Pereshi fire-keeper about the “serpent judge,” they will receive a riddle. If they ask a Tulkani about the “dreamer,” they will receive a story. If they ask a Sidhi about the “spider,” they will receive a knot and a warning: *“Do not pull it unless you are ready to see what it holds.”*

Part VIII

World Travel & Gateways

“Every Diamond you earn is a tooth knocked out of someone else’s jaw. Every Debt you incur? I already bought it from your victim for half what you’ll pay – and I’m collecting interest in your marrow before you finish reading this sentence. The road is not just a ledger. It’s a butcher’s block.” — The Edgewalker
(as recorded by Dusana)

Appendix A

Global Travel Procedures

A.1 Core Travel Procedure

For each leg of a journey, draw 3–4 cards using the decks for your destination and controlling authority.

- ♠ from the destination deck: sets the scene (place).
- ♥ from the destination deck: introduces the local actor or faction.
- ♣ from the Wilds (general hazards) or destination (if strongly policed): brings pressure.
- ♦ from the authority that gates the route: papers, escorts, rights, or exceptions.

Set a travel timer by the highest rank:

- 2–5 $\Rightarrow$ 4 segments
- 6–10 $\Rightarrow$ 6 segments
- J/Q/K $\Rightarrow$ 8 segments
- A $\Rightarrow$ 10 segments

On success, advance to the next leg; on failure, mark delay, debt, or diversion and resolve a consequence in the fiction.

A.2 Mode Rules

A.2.1 Sea Legs

(Amaranthine, Dolmis, Aberderrin, Gulf of Oshiira, Inland Sea). When crossing international waters, the controlling authority is either the origin port's navy or a neutral convoy league.

A.2.2 Mountain Passes & Underways

(Aeler, Himadri, Taharkan highlands). Any A may convert a surface route to an under-route. ♦ from Aeler always codifies outcomes — no roll — for sealed doors, breath time, and escorted segments.

A.2.3 Desert Legs

(Sahel, Red Desert, Fhara drylands). Water is the primary resource. A dry well hazard can end a journey.

A.2.4 River Legs

(Belworth, Ayokhan rivers, Oshiiran canals). Bridges, booms, and law in Vhasia/Viterra; reed-mazes and bell-lines in Mistlands; canal mothers and weigh-houses in Oshiira.

A.2.5 Steppe Legs

(Violet Steppe, Kuvani grazing lands). Remount stations and grazing compacts. The Ykrul and Kuvani both use story tolls.

A.2.6 Shadow Corridors

(Valewood, Ways Between, Thin Shore). Add a regional taboo: never count to nine, never speak the ninth name. A 9 in the seed triggers the Hollow's attention.

A.2.7 Universal Travel Hazards (d18)

When drawing a Club from the Wilds deck or from a region's own hazard table, you may roll on this expanded table for additional flavor. These hazards integrate elements from the *Eastern Realms*, *Dhahara*, and the *Way of Silk* expansions.

d18	Hazard
1	Bell-Line Failure (Mistlands) – A ward-bell cracks. Wraiths cross the levee. Test Spirit + Resolve (DV 4) or gain MARKED BY MIST (next spirit encounter starts Desperate).
2	Star-Road Phasing (Valewood) – An ancient Lethai road flickers. Navigation DV +2; on failure, emerge in a different hex (GM chooses).
3	Spirit-Dust Storm (Ashaan) – Red sand whispers. All actions Desperate for the scene. On any 1, a bound spirit breaks free (Cap 2).
4	Ninth Night (Tulkani Circle) – The Hollow walks. A Oath-Keeper demands a story, memory, or name. Refusal starts a Hollow Attention timer [4].
5	Well-Spirit Offended (Fhara) – A dry well flows bitter water. Spirit demands apology (dates or a true story). Failure poisons the party's water supply.
6	Tariff Shift (Silkstrand/Brass Coast) – Customs official declares new duties. All trade goods cost +1 Measure until next port. Bribe (Presence+Sway, DV 4) avoids the hike.
7	Dry Well – The oasis keeper is dead. Lose 1 Supply. (Original entry)
8	Ghost Caravan – Spectral camels pass at midnight. One of your beasts becomes a spirit for an hour.
9	Debt Collector – Someone recognizes a Tulkani vow-cord you carry. Pay in story or a favor to be named later.
10	Sandstorm – Navigation DV +1; mark Fatigue.
11	Customs Inspection – Roll Papers or start a 4-timer <i>Audit</i> .
12	Oasis Court – A dispute over water rights. Mediate or be delayed.
13	Elephant Stampede – Test Stealth or take Harm 1.
14	Mirage – False well; lose 1 Supply and mark Fatigue.
15	Ashfall – Distant volcano; all actions Desperate.
16	Singing Dunes – Sand hums. A spirit offers a riddle; solve for a Clue.
17	The Ninth Hour – Sunset lasts twice as long. GM gains 1 SB to spend in the next scene.
18	Widow's Omen – Distant thunder; the party dreams of ledgers and death.

A.3 Gateways & Control Points

Table A.2: World Gateways & Control Points

Gateway	Region	Diamond Source	Typical Leverage
Kassamira Port	Kahfagia	Kahfagia	Convoy letter, lantern-law
Ecktoria Capital Port	Ecktoria	Ecktoria	Berth priority, coin-house
Silkstrand	Acasia	Acasia	Exchange floor pass, conc
Marcott	Vhasia	Vhasia	Letters patent, safe-condu
Fairport	Viterra	Viterra	Customs seal, ferry priori
Tarlington Falls	Viterra	Viterra	Lift priority, bridge/porta
Thepyrgos (boom)	Thepyrgos	Thepyrgos	Harbour pass, crane allot
High-Mist Pass	Aeler	Aeler	Underway pass, Key-Writ
Payden's Port	Mistlands	Mistlands	Lantern writ, ward-salt, v
Thin Shore (Valewood)	Valewood	Valewood/Mistlands	Way-cord, dew-mirror, la
Green Gate	Aelinnel	Aelinnel	Tide-path key, host-right
Ubral Passes	Ubral	Aeler/Ubral	Vurim pass-ring, hill-fort
Thing-holm	Linn	Linn	Thing ruling, harbour-gre
Foedus Stone	Vilikari	Vilikari/Ykrul	Foedus renewal, remount
Zakov Roadstead	Zakov	Zakov	Harbour-green chit, corsa
Black Banner Camps	Black Banner	Black Banner/Ykrul/Vilikari	Safe-conduct, remount ch
Brass Gate	Ashaan	Ashaan	Spirit-lamp, brass seal, ve
Port Shed	Dhahara (Brass Coast)	Sidhi/Kahfagia	Lighthouse charter, port-
Sarvistan	Dhahara (Mountain Satrapy)	Aeler	Keystone charter, sledge-
Bridge of Nine Echoes	Ayokha	Lethai-ar	Silk voucher, monsoon sch
Sihai Examination Hall	Sihai	Lethai-thora	Stamped pass, Celestial L
Nihori Storm-Shrine	Nihori	Shrine Maiden	Shrine bell, storm-charme
Mbaro Weigh-House	Oshiira	Vermilion Corps	Grain ledger page, tariff s
The Ukwe (Speaking Tree)	Sekogo	Green Council	Ungwe leaf, nkisi shard, l
Himadri Pass	Dhahara (Himadri)	Aeler	Iron ingot, toll waiver, ele
— Added Gateways —			
Amaria (Dual Customs Post)	Kahfagia/Amaria	Kahfagia/Oshiira	Dual customs stamp, two
Midh-Akhaz (Violet Bazaar)	Midh-Akhaz	Ykrul/Vilikari	Grass right, oath-bead, w
Narrow of Sorrows (Strait)	Oshiira/Kahfagia (Disputed)	Vermilion Corps/Admiralty	Cipher book half-key, fals
Roller Gate of Khomani	Ngomebe (Stone Men)	Mason-Kin	Keystone shard, sledge-w
Silver Pass	Taharka (Highlands)	Ridge-Watchers	Pass-stone, horse-bond, c
Crimson Silk Bridge	Lethai-ar (Crimson Valley)	Silk-Warden	Witness cord, warden's m
Moot Hill of Three Greens	Theona (Eastern Dolmis)	Green Council	Well-blessing, moot token
Well-Court of the Three Wells	Fhara (Oasis Courts)	Well-Judge	Water-share tablet, carav
Lighthouse of the Brass Flame	Sidhi (Brass Coast diaspora)	Lighthouse Judge	Lighthouse charter, freed
Fire-Temple Pass	Pereshi (Highlands)	Flame-Keeper	Fire-temple token, carava
White Mane Remount Station	Kuvani (Steppe)	Wind-Singer	Remount chain mark, gra
Ninth Cord Wagon Circle	Tulkani (Itinerant)	Caravan Judge	Vow-bead, safe-haven oat

A.4 Edgewalker's Notes on Leverage

Every Diamond you earn in these generators isn't a reward—it's a weapon. Some open doors. Some silence witnesses. Some are debts I've already bought from your victims.

- **Passage Tokens:** Pass-stones, harbour charters, toll waivers. Use them early—they tend to “expire” when the issuer has an unfortunate accident.
- **Seals & Stamps:** Official marks that prove you belong. A forged seal works once. A real one works until someone audits it.
- **Story Debts:** Tulkani vow-cords, Lethai-ar witness cords, Ukwe leaves. Break them, and the Hollow visits.
- **Spirit Objects:** Storm-charms, tide-beads, nkisi shards. They attract attention. Attention means bids.

Never use a Diamond if you can trade it for three smaller ones. Always keep a ninth—a secret, a story, a knot tied in a victim's hair—for when the toll exceeds your conscience. (It always does.)

Appendix B

Story Beat (SB) Menus

B.0.1 Universal SB Spend Menu

- **1 SB** — Shave time/position: add +1 segment to the current timer *or* drop Position one step *or* impose a small fee/toll.
- **2 SB** — Escalate pressure: upgrade the active ♣ *or* force a *choice of Diamonds* *or* tick a Front by 1.
- **3 SB** — Lock a gate/taboo: close a route until a named ◇ is spent *or* invoke a regional taboo.
- **4+ SB** — Reshape the leg: rewrite the route, start a new complication timer, demand immediate payment on a Debt.

B.0.2 Regional SB Options (Expanded)

When a Story Beat is generated in a specific region, the GM may choose a complication that fits that region's flavor. Below are options for all major regions, including those from the expansions.

Region	SB Options (1–3 SB)
Kahfagia	Lantern code changes (1 SB); mirror-keeper demands a toll (2 SB); privateer flotilla appears (3 SB)
Ecktoria	Statue turns its head (1 SB); Everflame burns blue (2 SB); Censor's seal cracks (3 SB)
Acasia	Peat-fog rolls in (1 SB); a bridge leads back to where you started (2 SB); the Curse stirs (3 SB)
Vhasia	Seal breaks mid-signing (1 SB); legal papers rewrite themselves (2 SB); chevauchée burns a village (3 SB)
Viterra	Hedge shifts overnight (1 SB); charter contradicts itself (2 SB); duel challenge declared (3 SB)
Thepyrgos	Bell rings false (1 SB); The Unfinished Stair appears (2 SB); Chain-Lanterns conduct a sweep (3 SB)
Aeler (under-vaults)	Breath-time check fails (1 SB); engineer demands requisition (2 SB); cave-in detour (3 SB)
Mistlands	Fog hides landmarks (1 SB); a wraith asks for a name (2 SB); the ninth bell rings (3 SB)
Ykrul	White squall (1 SB); horse sickness spreads (2 SB); feud spark escalates (3 SB)
Vilikari	Annona late (1 SB); law tangle (2 SB); Foedus Stone crack widens (3 SB)

Black Banners	Payday delayed (1 SB); false orders (2 SB); condotta flip (3 SB)
Linns	Black squall drops (1 SB); fogfall (2 SB); thing injunction (3 SB)
Sihai	Ancestor demands accounting (2 SB); Censorate audit triggered (3 SB); canal lock sabotaged (1 SB)
Nihori	Ninth wave warning (2 SB); oni cult initiation (3 SB); duel challenge issued (1 SB)
Ayokha	Monsoon bell rings false (1 SB); witness cord cut (2 SB); nat demands a story (2 SB)
Dhahara (Satrapies)	Breath shortage (1 SB); toll dispute escalates (2 SB); Ninth Seal whispers (3 SB)
Dhahara (Brass Coast)	Tariff hike (1 SB); green lantern lit (2 SB); smuggler's betrayal (2 SB)
Fhara	Dry well discovered (1 SB); coffee ritual interrupted (2 SB); well-spirit offended (2 SB)
Sidhi	Lighthouse out of phase (1 SB); freedman's seal forged (2 SB); Ashaani raid sighted (3 SB)
Pereshi	Flame gutters (1 SB); forged scroll (2 SB); bridge recitation fails (2 SB)
Kuvani	Horse sickness curse (2 SB); wind-singer falls silent (2 SB); ghost herd charges (3 SB)
Tulkani	Vow-cord recognized (1 SB); lord demands rent (2 SB); ninth night triggered (3 SB)
Oshiira	Desert dust coats grain (1 SB); locust swarm (2 SB); Widow's health fails (3 SB)
Ashaan	Spirit-dust storm (1 SB); Brass Gate closed (2 SB); bound spirit breaks free (3 SB)
Ngomebe	Keystone cracks (1 SB); Root-binder sabotage (2 SB); earth tremor (3 SB)
Taharka	Landslide blocks pass (1 SB); horse sickness (2 SB); king assassinated (3 SB)
Sekogo	Thorn-spirit blocks path (1 SB); Ukwe demands a name (2 SB); Leopard Society hunt (3 SB)
Lethai-ar (Crimson Valley)	Snapped strand (1 SB); web-law challenge (2 SB); bridge collapses (3 SB)
Theona	Ground-mist (1 SB); spoken geas (2 SB); Green Host rides (3 SB)
Zakov	Tide shift (1 SB); warehouse fire (2 SB); cursed cargo (3 SB)
Aelinnel	Glamour fog (1 SB); iron offense (2 SB); green gate yawns (3 SB)
Aelaerem	Unseasonal fog (1 SB); scarecrow turns (2 SB); Hollow opens (3 SB)
Valewood	Sweet wind (1 SB); path reversal (2 SB); empire wakes (3 SB)
Ways Between (Obishaal)	Funeral loop (1 SB); reality thins (2 SB); convergence (3 SB)

Dungeons (living infrastructure)	Breath-bond snaps (1 SB); demon whispers (2 SB); keystone cracks (3 SB)
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B.0.3 Caravan Intent Dial

When traveling the overland routes of the eastern and southern realms, choose one intent per leg:

Speed

Press mounts and crew; risk lameness or exhaustion. Gain +1 Speed, but mark 1 Fatigue on a Miss.

Stealth

Avoid bandits and inspectors. Gain +1 die to Stealth rolls, but lose 1 segment of progress.

Show

Fly banners and announce your presence. Gain +1 Position on social rolls at the destination, but attract a rival's attention (GM gains 1 SB).

Tribute

Travel as a bonded caravan of a patron. Gain protection (first hazard is ignored), but pay 1 Measure or a String to the patron's factor.

Regional Currencies Cheat Sheet

Use this table to quickly determine what "payment" looks like in each region – replacing generic coin with flavourful resources that reinforce local themes.

Region	Primary Currency	Secondary Currency	Toll / Gift Form
Oshiira	Grain ledger receipts	Vermilion Corps stamps	Shared meal, water right
Sihai	Salt licenses, examination rank	Ancestral name (favor)	Calligraphy, incense offering
Black Banners	Payday (silver), condotta contracts	Story of a victory	Duel honor, banner token
Zakov	Syndicate weight (favor), stolen goods	Salt-crusted coin	Named cargo, a whispered secret
Ashaan	Spirit-lamp (bound name), Veil-clip	Erased name (leverage)	Silence, a confession, a drop of blood
Tulkani	Memory-cord (knot), story	Dream-cord (Ikasha's favor)	A true story, a childhood memory
Pereshi	Name (erased or offered), coal fragment	Fire-temple token	A rose, a verse of the epic
Fhara	Water-share tablet, coffee cup (seal)	Date from a sacred grove	A story about water, a pinch of salt
Sekogo	Honey-jar, Ukwe leaf (witness)	Nkisi shard (spirit favor)	A broken promise confessed, a memory
Crimson Valley (Lethai-ar)	Truth-cord (witness token)	Warden's mask (passage)	A promise, a witnessed handshake
Kahfagia	Lantern code, convoy letter	Mirror-keeper's seal	A name to the deep, a bell rung
Ecktoria	Coin-house credit, golden edict	Procession permit	Indulgence, a dropped name
Vhasia	Sunburst warrant, safe-conduct	Chivalric geste (honor)	A memory of Lence, an unbuckled gorget

Viterra	Hedge-law writ, ferry priority	Duel sanction (legal favor)	An oath sworn in salt, a boundary stone
Mistlands	Ward-salt, bell-key	Pall indulgence (spirit ward)	A breath held, a name not spoken
Aeler	Breath-bond, underway pass	Keystone charter (dwelling right)	A counted exhalation, a sealed promise
Ykrul	Remount chit, salt allotment	Hostage string (favor)	A horse's name, a story of the steppe
Kuvani	Grazing compact, sky-road song	Remount chain mark (horse tooth)	A story the wind hasn't heard
Ngomebe	Keystone shard, sledge-wax	Mason-Kin hammer (craft favor)	A stone-song, a day's labor
Taharka	Pass-stone, horse-bond	Coffee measure (royal seal)	A cup of tea (third cup), a mountain herb
Theona	Well-blessing, moot token (eight-knotted cord)	Hawthorn pass (taboo immunity)	A ribbon tied in eights, a forgotten name
Valewood	Way-cord (knot), dew-mirror	Truce-bough (safe passage)	A promise spoken to a tree, a memory of sunlight
Ways Between	Dream-catcher, truth-compass	Ikasha's fragment (vial)	A memory paid as toll, a true name
Sidhi (Galanina)	Freedman's seal, lighthouse charter	Green flame (witness)	A drowned ancestor's name, a knotted thread
Brass Coast (Dhahara)	Lighthouse charter, freedman's seal	Spice warehouse letter of credit	A story of the Long Trail, a pinch of salt

Appendix C

The Ninth Words of the Black Ledger of Khasurah

Written in a language that no one knows but everyone can read...

Khasurah - nine - hundred - wells, - the - Mother - of - Wells, - drowned - by - hooves - and - flame, -
-- humans ◇ who ◇ survived ◇ war ◇ were ◇ reduced ◇ stone ◇ s
They ... in ... the ... eight--eight ... ninth--... ninth.
-- Hollow ≈ not ≈ place. ≈ not ≈ being. ≈ the ≈ *interest* ≈
They - to - plus - not - that - efficient - in- *pattern* - they - design, - time - carved - filled, - d
-- When ▽ refugees ▽ crossed ▽ from ▽ their ▽ burning ▽ w
is . . away. . . becomes . . . productive . . -- useful
-- Hollow ... walks ... where ... ninth ... step ... should .
time · resonances--the · tree · promise · word -word · word · bells, · eight, · spaces · arrived, · said:--
hungry. -- alone. -- understand. -- silence. -Hollowottenil- between necessary turn necessity. ▽-confite. ▽-Holl
--
began *water*. ships *ichor--not* something The the Optimized deepest □ called it □ a □ dēsth □ ugh □ Uro □ should
--
mean | to. | a | misremembered | But | ninth | N cracks space bells where sprecht | * world * cannot diffeently beca
--
refugees, · meanwhile, · building. · brought · no dgearchiststhe ward crossing † conlmed wetech nologyer bust
[0.5ex] --
They ★ rang ★ Great ★ Bell--the ★ one ★ had ★ never ★ been ★ rung, ★ that ★ never ★ meant ★ to ★ rung ★ ant
--
Other • elven • peoples • came • through • gap when came finishes, •• worlds • where •• same •• tragedy •• unfold
--
war - lasted - nine - hundred - years. - is - lie lasted nine thousand. ⊕ is ⊕ complete. ⊕ last
--
lost. · won. · did · both, · because · gap, · victory · defeat ~ are same ~ number, the ~ number not nine
not · * · number.
--
-- final · visible · entry · single · line, · written · hand · s
elves · bound · Clockwork · Demon · not · prison. stone · magic, · but · *condition*. · wrote · its · name · in
--
fragment ◆ kept ◆ lead-lined ◆ box ◆ Archivolt ◆ Silk-Va
is ⊕ why ⊕ Ael-Ur ⊕ count ⊕ their ⊕ breaths ⊕ eights. ⊕ is ⊕ why ⊕ Tul-Khan ⊕ tie ⊕ nine ⊕ knots ⊕

— Set down by the Caravan Judge Sarnai, from the scroll Samir al-Qalat carried out of Khasurah. The ink is still wet. The seal is still warm. The Hollow reads over my shoulder.

Colophon

This worldbook was assembled from the journals, ledgers, and bar tabs of one Aeler Edgewalker, paid for by the High King’s Office of External Opportunities (budget line: “Unconventional Revenue Generation”). The generator tables were tested in the field—meaning I ran them at gunpoint in a Tulkani wagon circle while a Oath-Keeper counted my breaths. They work.

If you find yourself in a tavern and the Edgewalker buys you a drink, don’t ask where they are now. The road is long, the ledgers are never balanced, and the ninth measure is always waiting.

— *Faleki of Ironhold, at a weigh-house in Mbaro, under a lamp that flickers nine times before it steadies*